

CITY: Pg 2

Nurse held hostage, raped repeatedly

NATION: Pg 5

PM Modi vows NDA govt in Kerala after April 9 Assembly election

FILM: Pg 12

Dia recalls being tagged 'bad luck'

REGIONAL DIPLOMATS SEEK END TO WAR

Iran warns US against ground invasion

Claims it destroyed US E-3 AWACS plane; images show fuselage damage

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Iran has claimed to have significantly damaged a United States aircraft during a retaliatory missile and drone strike on an American air base in Saudi Arabia.

The strikes reportedly hit Prince Sultan Air Base, where the now-destroyed E-3 AWACS command and control plane was stationed alongside other US military assets.

Newly released images, published by Iran's Press TV, show the body of the plane damaged, with only the head and tail intact. The attack reportedly involved six ballistic missiles and 29 drones.

At least 10 US personnel were wounded, with two reported in serious condition, Associated Press reported. The strike involved an Iranian missile and several drones targeting the base.

Multiple refuelling aircraft were also damaged in the attack, preliminary reports indicate. The US Central Command (CENTCOM) has not commented on the incident.

A top Iranian official warned the US against a ground invasion, saying American troops would be set "on fire," as regional diplomats gathered in Pakistan on Sunday in a push to broker an end to the monthlong war.

Iran's parliament speaker, Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, dismissed weekend talks as a cover while the US dispatches additional troops to the Middle East. He said Iran was prepared to confront any American forces on its soil and would respond harshly against both US troops and Washington's regional allies, according to Iranian state media.

The remarks came as Pakistan said the foreign ministers of Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Egypt were holding talks in Islamabad without US or Israeli participation. Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif earlier said he and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian had held "extensive discussions" on the regional hostilities.

Yet there were few signs of progress as Israel and the US kept up strikes on Iran, and Tehran responded by firing missiles and drones across the region.

More than 3,000 people have been killed throughout the month-long war that began with US and Israeli strikes on Iran, triggering Iran's attacks on Israel and neighbouring Gulf Arab states.

Israel announced waves of incoming strikes from Iran on Sunday, and explosions could be heard throughout Tehran.



An Iranian Red Crescent member walks through Hypercar, an auto service centre damaged in March 1 strikes, in Tehran, Saturday

FILE PHOTO

HIGHLIGHTS

» Iran warns US troops would be "set on fire" if ground invasion occurs

» Iran's parliament speaker rejects talks, vows strong response to US presence

» Pakistan hosts Saudi, Turkish, Egyptian ministers for crisis talks

» Over 3,000 killed in month-long war sparked by US-Israel strikes on Iran

» Iran eases Hormuz transit slightly, allowing limited Pakistani vessels through

» US deploys more Marines; says objectives achievable without ground troops

Yet during the talks, Iran has eased some restrictions on commercial ships passing through the Strait of Hormuz. It agreed late Saturday to allow 20 more Pakistani-flagged vessels to transit the critical passageway, Pakistani officials said, adding to the select few it has let through as Iran works to choke but not cut off the strait entirely.

The weekend provided little sign of the talks narrowing the disconnect between the US and Iran. US officials have insisted the war may be nearing an inflexion point, but Iranian leaders continue to publicly reject negotiations.

To the contrary, the United States has dispatched thousands of additional Marines and paratroopers to the region. And the Iran-backed Houthis, who govern parts of Yemen, announced their long-awaited entry into the war, launching missiles toward what they called "sensitive Israeli military sites" for the first time on Saturday.

Despite the deployments, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Friday that Washington "can achieve all of our objectives without ground troops" as domestic opposition grows to expanding the war to a potential

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PM warns against politicising crisis due to West Asia conflict

Calls situation "challenging" during Mann Ki Baat address



Prime Minister Narendra Modi being felicitated during a public meeting, in Palakkad, Kerala

PTI

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/ PALAKKAD (KERALA): Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged all citizens to join hands to overcome the "challenging" situation emerging due to the ongoing "fierce war" in West Asia.

Addressing his monthly radio broadcast 'Mann Ki Baat', Modi also cautioned those politicising the present crisis and said there is no place for self-serving politics in the prevailing situation. He said those who are spreading rumours are causing major harm to the country.

"Presently, a fierce war is going on in our neighbourhood for a month. These certainly are challenging times.

Continued on P4

KEY POINTS

» Says no place for self-serving politics now

» Flags rumours as harmful to the country

» Advises citizens to trust only official government information

» Urges vigilance and responsible public behaviour

» Expresses confidence India will overcome crisis collectively

» Notes over 1 crore Indians living in Gulf countries

Delhi L-G engages with public on civic issues



NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday carried out an informal public outreach at Connaught Place, engaging directly with residents and visitors on everyday concerns and possible solutions.

During the visit, Sandhu revisited the area's culinary legacy, stopping at Keventers for a milkshake and later tasting 'kadhi chawal' at Jain Chawal Wale, according to a post by Lok Niwas Delhi on X. Photographs shared by the Lieutenant Governor's Secretariat showed him moving through the busy commercial hub and interacting with the public.

Joining queues like other customers, Sandhu ate while standing among patrons and spoke with them about livelihoods, career prospects, aspirations and routine challenges, officials said. He also reviewed ground conditions, taking note of sanitation and traffic management across the area.

In conversations with citizens, the Lieutenant Governor invited suggestions to address civic concerns and said governance should remain people-centric, with solutions shaped at the grassroots. He called for a "bottom-up" approach rather than a "top-down" model.

See P3

Bihar CM may resign from Legislative Council today

PATNA: Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar is expected to resign from the state Legislative Council on March 30, a move that will clear the way for him to step down as chief minister and take up his new role in the Rajya Sabha, according to sources.

Kumar, who was elected to the Upper House of Parliament on March 9, had earlier announced on March 5 his intention to resign as chief minister, citing a long-held desire to serve in both Houses of the state legislature and Parliament.

Janata Dal (United) MLA Anant Kumar Singh confirmed the

Continued on P4

Airlines to offer 60% seats without extra charges from April 20

NEW DELHI: Airlines will offer at least 60 per cent of seats on every flight free of charge from April 20, following new directions by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation. The revised Air Transport Circular, issued on March 20, mandates transparent seat allocation and clear communication of free seat availability.

The regulator said "60 per cent of the seats in any flight shall be offered free of charge," up from the current 20 per cent. It also asked airlines to seat passengers on the same PNR together where possible.

Airlines typically charge Rs 200 to Rs 2,100 for seat selection. IndiGo, Air India and SpiceJet have opposed the move, citing revenue concerns.

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CULTURAL ROOTS



A woman makes a 'rangoli' during a festival in Chennai, on Sunday

PTI

In today's paper

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TELANGANA ASSEMBLY PASSES PARENTAL SUPPORT BILL

Telangana mandates care for elderly parents

MPOST BUREAU

HYDERABAD: The Telangana Legislative Assembly on Sunday passed a Bill aimed at securing the welfare of senior citizens while also introducing a separate legislation to address hate speech and hate crimes, marking a significant legislative push by the Congress government led by Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy.

The Assembly approved the "Telangana Employees Accountability and Monitoring of Parental Support Bill, 2026," which mandates that public representatives, government employees, and private sector workers provide care and financial support to their elderly parents. Non-compliance will attract a penalty in the form of a salary deduction of 15 per cent or Rs 10,000, whichever is lower, payable directly to the parents. The Chief Minister said the measure goes beyond the existing Maintenance and Welfare of

CLOSER LOOK

» Salary deduction up to 15% or Rs 10,000 for neglecting parents

» Law applies to public representatives, government and private employees

» Measure expands scope beyond 2007 central senior citizens law

» CM Revanth Reddy calls it a social responsibility initiative

» Vijaypat Singhania case cited during

Assembly discussion

» Minister Konda Surekha stresses duty towards parents

» BJP and CPI extend support to the Bill

» Separate Hate Speech and Hate Crimes Bill introduced

» Minimum one-year jail, up to seven years and Rs 50,000 fine for offences

» Repeat offenders face two to ten years jail and Rs 1 lakh fine

Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007, by widening its scope to include elected representatives and private employees.

During the debate, Reddy referred to the case of businessman Vijaypat Singhania to underline the vulnerability of parents abandoned by their children. "If anyone neglects their parents, they should be brought under the purview of the law," he said, adding that such steps were necessary as a social responsibility. Minister Konda Surekha said, "There is no life without parents. It is everyone's responsibility to look after them," while BJP MLA Payal Shankar termed the Bill the first of its kind and suggested increasing the financial provision. CPI member K Sambasiva Rao also extended support.

Separately, the government introduced the Telangana Hate Speech and Hate Crimes (Prevention) Bill, 2026. The proposed law prescribes a minimum prison term of one year, extendable to seven years, along with a fine of Rs 50,000 for offences. Repeat offenders could face between two and ten years of imprisonment and a

Continued on P4

Incarceration without trial is punishment: SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Observing that incarceration without trial amounts to punishment, the Supreme Court granted bail to a Punjab resident in an attempt-to-murder case, noting that he had spent two years in jail without the trial even commencing.

A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and P V Varale, in its recent order, said Pradeep Kumar alias Banu was booked for various offences, including attempt to murder, in February 2024, but the prosecution is yet to examine any one of the 23 witnesses related to the case.

Continued on P4



ACCUSED ARRESTED

# Nurse held hostage, raped repeatedly by truck driver in Nuh

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**GURUGRAM:** A 25-year-old nurse from Punjab was allegedly held hostage and raped multiple times by a truck driver for several days in a village in Haryana's Nuh district, police said on Sunday.

The nurse alleged that the accused pressured her to convert to Islam by promising to marry her. When she refused, he threatened to kill and make her objectionable video viral on social media, they added.

The victim somehow escaped on Saturday night and went to the Ferozpur Jhirka city police station, where, after registering an FIR, police arrested the accused truck driver, Zaheer, 20, SHO Kuldeep Singh said.

The accused, a resident of Dhondh village in Nuh district, was produced in a Nuh court on Sunday and sent into judicial custody, he said.

According to the police, the victim, a resident of Punjab's Firozpur, in her complaint said that she met Zaheer on social media about a year ago.

As their conversation pro-

Four in cop net for posing as bank agents and extorting motorists

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** Four members of a high-tech roadside extortion racket have been arrested by Delhi Police for allegedly posing as bank recovery agents and targeting motorists using a mobile application.

The accused — Prince (22), Aakash alias Akku (25), Shivam (23) and Teetu alias Tittu (22), all residents of Baghpat in Uttar Pradesh — were apprehended following a complaint lodged at Shakarpur Police Station. According to police, the gang used an app to identify vehicles with pending loan instalments and intercepted motorists on busy roads, threatening and extorting money through digital payments.

The case came to light after Keshav Kumar alleged that he was stopped near Vikas Marg, close to the ITO area, on March 26. The accused allegedly restrained and assaulted him while posing as recovery agents, and forced him to transfer Rs 18,000 online.

Police used technical surveillance and local intelligence to trace the accused, with inputs from a secret informer and mobile location data aiding the investigation.

Five mobile phones and a car used in the crime have been recovered.

## Cops bust inter-state stolen mobile racket

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi Police has busted an inter-state racket dealing in stolen mobile phones and arrested two men, seizing 83 high-end handsets from their possession, officials said on Sunday.

Acting on a tip-off, a team conducted a raid at a rented premises in Yamuna Vihar on Friday, where the accused -- Saavej, 34, and Fardeen, 25 -- were caught red-handed while packing stolen mobile phones for dispatch, police said.

A sealed carton containing 83 stolen mobile phones of brands like Apple, Samsung, OnePlus, Vivo, Oppo and Realme was recovered from the spot.

"Preliminary investiga-



### KEY POINTS

» The victim somehow escaped on Saturday night and went to the Ferozpur Jhirka city PS, where, after registering an FIR, police arrested the accused truck driver, Zaheer, 20, police said

» The accused, a resident of Dhondh village in Nuh district, was produced in a Nuh court on Sunday and sent into judicial custody, he said

gressed, the accused lured her into believing he was married.

After this, the accused lured her to a hotel on the pretext of hosting a party, where he forcibly raped her and filmed an obscene video.

He continued to blackmail her by threatening to make the video viral. He raped her multiple times and also extorted around Rs 1.5 lakh, she added.

"On March 20, the accused took me to his village, where I was held captive and raped. During this time, he pressured me to convert to Islam. When I resisted, I was beaten and threatened with death."

On Saturday night, she somehow escaped from the clutches of the accused and reached Ferozpur Jhirka police station, the victim said in her complaint.

Following the complaint, a case has been registered against the accused under various sections, including rape, blackmail, and under the Haryana Prevention of Unlawful Conversion of Religion Act 2022 at Ferozpur Jhirka police station, police said.

The victim returned home with her family, and a further probe is underway," the SHO said.

## Student dies after jumping from 28th floor in Noida; cops examine mental stress angle

DIPIKA KIROLA

**NOIDA:** A 21-year-old B.Tech student allegedly died by suicide after jumping from the 28th floor of a high-rise residential society in Noida's Sector 32 early on Sunday morning, police said.

The incident occurred at Amour Society under the jurisdiction of Sector 24 police station. The woman, identified as Arpita, was a native of Basti district and was pursuing engineering from a private university in Punjab. She had reportedly returned to Noida a few days ago. Police said they received information about the incident early in the morning, following which a team rushed to the spot. She had allegedly jumped from the balcony of her family's flat on the 28th floor



and was declared dead at the scene. The body has been sent for post-mortem examination. "We reached the spot immediately after receiving information. The body has been sent for post-mortem and further investigation is underway," a senior police officer from Sector 24 police station said.

Preliminary inquiry suggests that the woman may have

## 2 hurt as cars collide

**NEW DELHI:** Two men were injured after two cars collided near RP Chowk in northwest Delhi's Pitampura early on Sunday morning, police said.

The accident occurred around 5.30 am on March 29 near RP Chowk, opposite GD Goenka School, under the jurisdiction of Maurya Enclave Police Station. Police received a PCR call from Raghav Mathur, who reported that a car coming from the Netaji Subhash

Place side rammed into his Maruti Brezza at the intersection. Parth Gambir (21), a resident of Pitampura, sustained injuries and was admitted to Fortis Hospital, Shalimar Bagh. Mathur suffered minor injuries and was taken to Bhagwan Mahavir Hospital. The other driver was also medically examined.

Police have seized both vehicles and launched an investigation. **MPOST**

# Delhi Police bust dating app robbery gang; five nabbed for abducting, extorting victim

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** A Delhi man was allegedly choked until he lost consciousness after being lured, abducted and robbed by five individuals through a dating application in south-east Delhi's Kalkaji area. A 20-year-old woman and her four associates have been arrested in connection with the case, police said.

The incident came to light on March 25, when the complainant, Anurup Narula, reported that he had been contacted on a dating app by a woman using the profile name 'Sherry'. She allegedly persuaded him to meet her at Nehru Place.

According to police, when Narula reached the location, he was confronted and assaulted by three male associates of the woman, who then



forced him into a white Hyundai Aura car. He was allegedly choked until he lost consciousness and repeatedly threatened during the ordeal.

Police said the accused coerced the victim into transferring around Rs 7 lakh through multiple channels, including UPI transactions,

### TAKEAWAYS

» The incident came to light when the complainant, Anurup Narula, reported that he had been contacted on an app by a woman using the profile name 'Sherry'

» The accused coerced the victim into transferring around Rs 7 lakh through multiple channels, including UPI

ATM withdrawals and credit card payments. After the money was transferred, he was abandoned at Nehru Place and warned against approaching the police.

Based on the complaint, an FIR was registered at Kalkaji Police Station under relevant sections of the

Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

A special team was formed under the Deputy Commissioner of Police (South-East) to investigate the case. The team, led by Inspector R.S. Dagar under the supervision of ACP Operations Rattan Lal, analysed CCTV footage, which helped identify one of the vehicles used in the crime.

Investigators also traced suspicious financial transactions and linked them to a phone number.

Further technical analysis, including call detail records, open-source intelligence inputs, automatic number plate recognition systems and FASTag data, led to the identification of a second vehicle and the accused.

Multiple raids were conducted at different locations, resulting in the arrest of Rishabh (25) along with

one of the vehicles. His associates — Nabojit Dey (30), Sanjay alias Joey (28), and Harleen Kaur alias Jenny (20) — were apprehended from Malviya Nagar, while another accused, Sahil Chauhan, was also arrested.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly confessed that Harleen Kaur used dating applications to lure victims to pre-decided locations, where her accomplices would rob them.

Police said two Hyundai Aura cars and five mobile phones have been recovered, and the financial trail of the robbed money has been tracked through bank accounts linked to the accused. None of the arrested individuals was found to have any previous criminal record.

Further investigation is underway.

## Fire at Bawana unit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** A fire broke out in a plastic factory in the Bawana industrial area of outer Delhi on Sunday afternoon, an official of the Delhi Fire Services said.

The blaze was reported at 4.30 pm at a unit located at Sector-5, near Samosa Chowk, he said. Three water tenders and two water bowlers were rushed to the spot in the initial response. But more fire tenders were rushed due to the category of the fire. No one has sustained any injury.

## Four injured after jumping from 1st floor to escape Gokalpuri fire

**NEW DELHI:** Four people, including a child, were injured after they jumped from the first floor of a residential building in northeast Delhi's Gokalpuri area to escape a fire that broke out in the early hours of Sunday.

The incident was reported around 2.30 am from a house in F block in the Chand Bagh area near Bhajanpura when the building was engulfed in heavy smoke after two scooters and a motorcycle parked on the ground floor caught fire, the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) said.

Eight other residents, including children, who were trapped on the second, third and fourth floors, also managed to save their lives when the firefighters reached the spot and rescued them.

An official said that by the

time the firefighters reached the spot, four people, three women, along with a child, had already jumped.

"They were identified as Nikhat (22), Rashida (50), Soni (25) and Ashif (2). All four were taken to Jag Pravech Chand Hospital and discharged after first aid," said Anoop Singh, Station Officer at Geeta Colony Fire Station.

Eyewitnesses said they woke up to loud cries for help and a burning smell in the night as panic spread through the building.

"I woke up to loud cries and a burning smell around 2:30 am. When I stepped out, flames were coming from the parking area, and thick smoke was rising fast. We tried to alert everyone and help them come out," a local said.

He further said that children were crying, and people were trying to find a way out as the staircase was completely choked with smoke.

Another local said that people were shouting to the residents to jump from the first floor. "They were crying and screaming for help. Locals helped them to rush them to nearby hospitals for treatment," she said.

Eyewitnesses added that residents on the upper floors were struggling to breathe due to the smoke and were trying to reach the terrace.

Thick smoke engulfed the building, forcing panicked residents onto the street as firefighters carried out rescues. The structure was charred and blackened. Officials said the fire was doused by 3.50 am. **PTI**

## Four arrested as police bust inter-state drug network

sules valued at approximately Rs 1 crore, he said.

"The operation began on March 17 following inputs about the movement of a drug consignment in northeast Delhi. Acting on the inputs, a team laid a trap near Shiv Vihar Tiraha on Johripur Road," the officer said.

During the operation, one accused, identified as Nitin Pathak, 20, along with a juvenile, was intercepted



while transporting narcotics on a motorcycle.

The team recovered 11,900

Alprazolam tablets weighing 1.91 kg and 825 Tramadol tablets weighing 0.49 kg from their possession, along with the motorcycle.

During interrogation, Pathak disclosed details of his associates, leading to further proceedings in Uttar Pradesh and Delhi. "Subsequently, a raid was conducted at a medical store in Bhopura in Uttar Pradesh, owned by co-accused Prem Singh Yadav, 30, from

where 2,250 Tramadol capsules weighing 1.218 kg were recovered. He was arrested on March 19," the officer said.

Further investigation led to the arrest of Shalu Kumar, 45, from Laxmi Nagar on March 21, after 11,955 Alprazolam tablets weighing 1.627 kg were recovered from his residence. On March 23, another accused, Sanjay Singh, 36, was arrested following disclosures made during the investigation. **MPOST**

## DU unveils Prerna Bhawan student centre

New multi-storey facility to house DUSU offices, seminar hall, library and gym

ANAMTA FATIMA

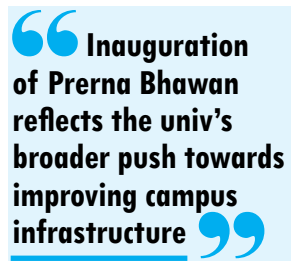
**NEW DELHI:** University of Delhi has inaugurated a modern student centre, Prerna Bhawan, aimed at enhancing student engagement and strengthening institutional support for student leadership. Located within the Faculty of Social Sciences campus, opposite Ramjas College, the facility will serve as the office space for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU).

The multi-storey building is equipped with a range of student-centric amenities. The ground floor houses a cafeteria with seating for over 50 individuals, along with a utility shop, kitchen, and storeroom. A gymnasium and games area



have been developed in the basement, while the first floor includes a seminar hall with a seating capacity of 120. The second floor accommodates offices for key DUSU office-bearers, including the president, vice-president, secretary, and joint secretary, along with a meeting room and pantry. The third floor features a library and reading hall. Separate washroom facilities for men and women have been provided on each floor.

The inauguration of Prerna Bhawan reflects the university's broader push towards improving campus infrastructure and fostering a more inclusive and participatory student environment. In a parallel initiative, Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh recently launched "Coffee with



VC", an interactive platform designed to facilitate direct dialogue between students and the university administration. The inaugural session saw students from Miranda House engaging in an informal discussion with the VC, raising academic and campus-related concerns. Emphasising the importance of technological awareness, he encouraged students to "make

AI your assistant, not your master," while also underlining ethical values and nation-building.

Meanwhile, the university has lifted a month-long ban on protests and introduced revised guidelines for campus demonstrations. Organisers are now required to submit a signed application to the Proctor's Office and local police authorities at least 72 hours in advance, detailing the nature and logistics of the event. The participation of outsiders has been prohibited, with violations attracting disciplinary action, including possible expulsion.

These developments signal a calibrated approach by the university to balance student expression with administrative oversight.

## Over 100 Delhi Police personnel honoured

**NEW DELHI:** As many as 106 Delhi Police personnel of the East District were honoured with commendation certificates and cash rewards for their performance and dedication to duty, officials said on Sunday.

The ceremony was attended by assistant commissioners of police, station house officers, and the in-charge of the anti-narcotics squad, along with the awardees.

The recognition was aimed at encouraging professionalism and sustained commitment within the force, officials said.

Senior officers noted that such initiatives help boost morale and reinforce high standards of policing across the district. **MPOST**



'GOVERNANCE SHOULD BE BOTTOM-UP RATHER THAN TOP-DOWN'

# CP stopover: L-G queues, connects

AIMAN FATIMA

**NEW DELHI:** Continuing his series of informal public outreach visits, Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday interacted with citizens at Connaught Place, engaging with people from diverse backgrounds, particularly youth and working professionals.

The visit, like his previous engagements, was unplanned and aimed at understanding ground realities through direct interaction. The L-G was seen standing in a queue at the popular Jain Chawal Wale, where he bought kadhi chawal and shared the space with other visitors while conversing with them about their concerns, careers, livelihoods and aspirations.

During the interaction, Sandhu stressed the importance of citizen-driven governance. "Experience has taught me that governance had to be people centric and solutions to people's issues had to come from people themselves," he said. He further added that governance should be "bottom-up" rather than "top-down," highlighting



the need for policies shaped by public feedback.

After his stop at Jain Chawal Wale, the LG walked to Keventers, where he continued engaging with citizens over milkshakes. Alongside these interactions, he also assessed civic conditions such as sanitation and traffic management in the area, while gathering

“Experience has taught me that governance had to be people centric and solutions to people's issues had to come from people themselves — L-G Sandhu

feedback from visitors who had come to Connaught Place from different parts of Delhi.

Officials said such visits are part of an ongoing effort by the L-G to maintain direct contact



with residents and understand local challenges beyond formal meetings. Sandhu also encouraged people to share practical solutions to everyday issues, reinforcing his approach to participatory governance.

The Lieutenant Governor has undertaken similar outreach visits in various parts of the city in recent weeks, including Model Town, Vasant Vihar, Chittaranjan Park and the Red Fort, where he engaged with citizens in informal settings.

These interactions, according to officials, are helping the administration gain real-time insights into public concerns while fostering greater trust between citizens and the government.

## CIVIC RESET: Mayor bats for no-jail norms

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Mayor of Delhi Raja Iqbal Singh on Sunday said the proposed amendments to the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act, 1957, are aimed at decriminalising minor civic offences and removing imprisonment provisions, pitching the move as part of a broader push for "citizen-friendly" governance.

"The intent is to move away from punitive enforcement. Minor civic lapses should not lead to criminal proceedings or imprisonment," Singh said, adding that the amendments aim to make municipal laws "more humane, practical and facilitative."

According to an official statement, the proposed changes seek to replace criminal penalties for minor and technical violations with monetary fines, reducing litigation and alleged harassment, while encouraging voluntary compliance.

The statement comes against the backdrop of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, which was introduced by Minister of State for Commerce and Industry

Jitin Prasad in the Lok Sabha on Friday and proposes multiple amendments in the DMC Act.

The bill proposes a wider overhaul of penalties under the act, including steep hikes in fines for civic violations such as pet dogs roaming without a leash, sanitation lapses and illegal occupation of buildings, while shifting adjudication of most offences from courts to municipal officers.

"The focus is on ease of living and ease of doing business. Licensing norms are being simplified, and compliance burden reduced so that citizens and businesses can function without fear of criminal action for minor violations," he said.

The amendments propose scrapping jail terms for several minor offences, including certain employment-related defaults, and removing obsolete provisions, while increasing penalties in select cases to ensure deterrence against repeated or serious violations.

Officials said the reforms are aimed at reducing unnecessary legal proceedings, improving administrative efficiency and promoting a trust-based governance framework.

## Subsidy bill rises on power, free bus travel in 2025-26

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

**NEW DELHI:** The subsidy bill of the Delhi government towards the free bus travel scheme for women and electricity has enhanced substantially even as funds for its ambitious IT projects have faced cuts, according to revised budget estimates for the current year.

The modified revised estimates (RE) figures released recently by the Finance department showed that the outlay for power subsidy has been increased to around Rs 4,200 crore, compared to the Budget Estimate (BE) of Rs 3,849 crore for the year.

The revision reflects additional requirements to clear pending dues and meet higher demand under the electricity subsidy scheme due to growing consumer numbers.

The Delhi government provides free electricity up to 200 units of monthly consumption, and those using 201 to 400 units are paid a 50 per cent subsidy.

The RE for the Transport department showed that subsidy to DTC for female commuters (eligible for free travel in public transport buses) has gone up to Rs 328 crore against the budget estimate (BE) of Rs 240 crore. The subsidy for Cluster service for free travel is also revised to Rs 342 crore from the BE of Rs 200 crore in 2026-27.

The total amount of subsidy to female commuters has increased to Rs 670 crore against the BE of Rs 440 crore, documents showed.

According to budget (RE) documents, the Information Technology department had an outlay of Rs 690.5 crore for the 2025-26 financial year, but revised estimates peg actual spending at just Rs 215 crore, a steep shortfall of nearly 69 per cent.

Officials said the RE estimates show cuts in various IT initiatives, including the Unified Data Hub project, which was allocated Rs 250 crore.

The RE for the project was slashed to Rs 6 crore now, as the current fiscal is around closure.

## Handloom meets cinema at IFFD

AIMAN FATIMA

**NEW DELHI:** A unique fusion of fashion, culture and cinema took centre stage at the International Film Festival Delhi (IFFD) 2026, as a grand showcase titled "The Loom & The Lens: Weaving Stories. Framing Legacy" celebrated India's rich handloom heritage at Bharat Mandapam.

Organised by Delhi Tourism in collaboration with the Development Commissioner (Handlooms) and Shikha's Kariigari, the event brought together traditional weaving and cinematic storytelling in a visually immersive presentation.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta highlighted the cultural significance of the initiative, stating, "IFFD Delhi is a celebration of cinema, India's cultural imagination and storytelling legacy. Initiatives like 'The Loom & The

Lens' beautifully position Delhi as a confluence of heritage and modern creativity." She added, "Handloom and cinema are two of India's most powerful storytelling traditions... Together, they preserve our collective memory and identity."

Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra said the festival is evolving into a global platform. "The International Film Festival Delhi is emerging as a global cultural platform, and through initiatives like 'The Loom & The Lens', we are expanding its canvas beyond cinema," he said, adding that it reflects the spirit of "Ek Bharat, Shreshth Bharat."

The showcase featured three thematic segments. The opening sequence, "Handloom to Silver Screen," revisited iconic saree styles inspired by Indian cinema from the 1940s to present day. The

second segment, "From the Weavers of India," displayed diverse handloom traditions including Banarasi, Chanderi, Venkatagiri and Kuthampully weaves.

The grand finale paid tribute to "Vande Mataram," marking its 150th anniversary through hand-painted sarees inspired by traditional art forms such as Madhubani, Warli and Pattachitra.

Dr. M. Beena, Development Commissioner (Handlooms), said, "It is heartening to see handloom being integrated into a global cultural platform like IFFD." Designer Shikha Ajmera added, "For me, a saree is not just a garment, but a moving canvas."

The showcase, directed by Sandesh Navlakha, concluded with widespread appreciation, reinforcing Delhi's position as a vibrant cultural hub blending tradition with contemporary creativity.

## GB Road pause: Healing amid hustle

SAUMYA SHUKLA

**NEW DELHI:** In a small hall at a multi-storey brothel in Delhi's red-light area, Garstin Bastion Road, popularly known as GB Road, about 40 sex workers paused their daily routines and gathered for a session on mental health. During the two-hour session, the hall echoed with affirmations such as "Main khud ke liye garv mehsos karti hoon" (I feel proud of myself).

Handling between 15 and 20 customers a day and often under the influence of intoxicants, these moments provide them with a scarce respite and an opportunity to laugh.

In the hall, which has five small enclosures, each measuring 3 feet by 5 feet, used by the women to sleep and carry out their work, the sex workers — aged between 20 and 50 — were asked to write their names on sheets marked with different emojis to symbolise their moods. "These women struggle to write their names. Most of them have little understanding of what constitutes a crime against them. Their internalised trauma has made them numb to physical pain," said an NGO worker who counsels them regularly.

The programme was led by Sub-Inspector Kiran, popularly known as 'Lady Singham', who heads the All-Women Police Post (Mahila Police Chowki) at GB Road, in collaboration with an NGO.

The Mahila Police Chowki has, since its inception in February 2024 as one of the first two all-women police posts in the city, emerged as a quiet yet powerful



Programme was led by SI Kiran, popularly known as 'Lady Singham', who heads the All-Women Police Post (Mahila Police Chowki) at GB Road, in collaboration with an NGO

space for empowerment in an area that houses hundreds of multi-storey brothels and over 1,000 sex workers. The police post has been running regular skill development and awareness programmes aimed at helping women from economically weaker sections move towards self-reliance. Coaching classes, makeup artist training, sewing courses, cooking sessions, aerobics, and counselling are among the initiatives conducted on the first floor of the police post. Other activities include embroidery, bag-making, pot-making, and creative exposure through film-related initiatives.

Self-defence and awareness sessions are also held regularly. On March 22, around 50 women participated in a police-

led programme where they were sensitised about their rights. Educational activities are conducted for children in the area as well, benefiting over 50 girls with basic education and introductory computer knowledge.

Health and hygiene form a key component of the initiative. Regular health camps have been organised since 2023, benefiting both sex workers and residents. Nearly 500 individuals have been provided with spectacles, while dental check-ups are conducted with support from Maulana Azad Dental Hospital. Awareness on hygiene, including the distribution of sanitary napkins and guidance on safe practices, is also carried out.

Mental health counselling is offered for nearly 20 days a

month at a dedicated counselling room within the police chowki. De-addiction awareness campaigns and psychological assessments are also part of the outreach.

But while the aforementioned facts provide data, witnessing real-life impact tells a story of hope and courage. In one case, a woman rescued from a brothel, along with her two children, including a son with multiple disabilities, was provided medical care and shelter, with both children now pursuing education.

Another woman trained in handicrafts and cake baking is currently employed at a restaurant in Rajouri Garden. Others have been trained in makeup artistry, paper craft, and similar skills to support self-employment. One woman was also provided with an e-rickshaw, which she now drives to earn a livelihood.

Speaking to PTI, Pooja (name changed), aged around 35 years, who has been attending regular coaching classes for six months, said, "I have never felt more confident than this. I had no idea how to even spell my name. Today, I can write it and also understand the basics. Whenever we feel something wrong is happening with us, we can go to the chowki and freely tell madam (Sub-Inspector Kiran)." Police officials said over 50 people, including minors, have been rescued from brothel houses so far since the post came into existence, with several rehabilitated through shelter homes, skill training, and employment opportunities.

PTI

## Forged no-entry permit racket busted in E Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi Traffic Police has busted a racket involved in the use of forged no-entry permissions by commercial vehicle operators in east Delhi, arresting one person and seizing a light goods vehicle, an official said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Mohammad Saleem, 45, a resident of Sunder Nagri, was apprehended by traffic staff of Nand Nagri Circle during a special enforcement drive, he said.

After the police received information regarding certain commercial vehicle drivers operating during restricted hours using fabricated no-entry permissions (NEPs), traffic personnel were deployed at key points to verify documents of commercial vehicles during restricted hours, a senior police officer said. On March 27, at around 6 pm, a team intercepted a Tata Ace vehicle near Loni Golchakkar on Wazirabad Road. The vehicle was moving towards Khajuri Khas dur-

ing the restricted time window between 5 pm and 11 pm, when entry of such vehicles is prohibited, he said.

"During inspection, the driver displayed a purported NEP pasted on the windscreen. However, verification through the official challan system revealed that no such permission had been issued for the vehicle, confirming that the document was forged," he added.

The accused was detained and later handed over to the Gokulpuri police station along with the vehicle. The police registered a case and initiated an investigation, police said.

During interrogation, Saleem disclosed that he had not applied for any legitimate no-entry permission. He allegedly procured the forged document through an acquaintance, Nazim, who introduced him to an unidentified person near the Burari Transport Authority. Efforts are underway to identify and apprehend other persons involved in the racket, police said.

## Capital records 36.2 deg Celsius

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi saw the maximum temperature rise to 36.2 degrees Celsius, 3.6 notches above the seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The minimum temperature settled at 19.8 degrees Celsius, 1.7 notches above the seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

Safdarjung recorded a maximum temperature of 36.2 degrees Celsius; Palam 35.7 degrees Celsius; Lodhi Road 35.1 degrees Celsius; the Ridge 35.3 degrees Celsius, and Ayanagar 35.6 degrees Celsius, the IMD data showed.

The weather department has issued a yellow alert and forecast very light to light rainfall in the national capital during the afternoon and evening, accompanied by gusty winds on Monday.

The maximum and minimum temperatures are expected to hover around 31 and 21 degrees Celsius, respectively.

'I HAVE BEEN DOING THIS SINCE 1995, BUT THIS IS THE WORST PHASE. I WILL RETURN TO MY VILLAGE NEXT MONTH AND TAKE UP FARMING'

## Flame freeze: Gas crisis chills Lajpat Nagar's sizzling street-food scene



ANAMITA FATIMA

**NEW DELHI:** A sharp disruption in LPG supply across parts of the Capital has begun to leave its mark not only in households but in the bustling commercial kitchens of Lajpat Nagar, one of Delhi's most vibrant street food hubs. From iconic stalls to modest carts, vendors are grappling with soaring prices, erratic supply, and an uncertain future.

On the ground, the situation appears far more severe. At a popular ram laddoo stall,

Suresh, a vendor, described the daily struggle to procure commercial cylinders. "Supply comes only every two or three days. One cylinder is never enough for us," he said, adding that he has been forced to buy cylinders at Rs 6,000, while domestic ones cost around Rs 4,000 in the open market.

For many, even these inflated rates offer no guarantee of availability. Bajrinaath, a street vendor selling boiled eggs and bread omelette, spoke of a breaking point. Supporting a family of six in his hometown,

he now finds it impossible to sustain his cart. "I have been doing this since 1995, but this is the worst phase. I will return to my village next month and take up farming," he said, recalling a time when eggs cost just a few rupees and survival in the city seemed attainable.

Several vendors echoed similar concerns, stating that despite being willing to pay Rs 3,000-Rs 4,000, cylinders remain out of reach. The crisis has not spared even well-known establishments such as Dolma Auntie Momos and

Avantika Food Corner, which reportedly faced temporary closures during the peak shortage. At a local dhaba, the owner has resorted to cooking on a traditional mud stove using coal. Serving nearly 200 customers daily, he said shutting down would mean losing years of trust. "This is the most expensive cylinder phase I have seen in my life," he noted, adding that the burden ultimately falls heavier on those with even fewer resources.

The issue also recently echoed within the Municipal

Corporation of Delhi House, where AAP councillors staged protests demanding urgent discussion on the reported shortage of LPG cylinders. Terming it a matter of public urgency, they raised slogans and carried placards, highlighting the distress spreading across the city's informal economy.

As supply constraints persist, the crisis underscores a deeper vulnerability in the city's food economy where the cost of a flame now threatens livelihoods, traditions, and the very rhythm of everyday life.



INAUGURATES DISTRICT COURT COMPLEX IN KARGIL

# CJI: Geographical distance must not become barrier to justice delivery

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LEH: Stressing that access to justice must transcend physical boundaries, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Sunday said that geographical distance should not become a barrier in the delivery of justice.

The CJI was speaking after virtually inaugurating a newly constructed district court complex at Kargil from here, marking a significant milestone in the judicial infrastructure of the Union territory of Ladakh.

The ceremony was attended by Ladakh Lieutenant Governor V K Saxena, Chief Justice of the High Court of J&K and Ladakh, Arun Palli, and judges of the high court.

“Geographical constraints must not impede justice delivery,” the CJI said, describing the occasion as a landmark step towards strengthening access to justice in remote regions.

He also said that Kargil



CJI Justice Surya Kant being accorded a Guard of Honour during the inauguration of the newly constructed district court complex, in Leh

PTI

Highlights

- » The new complex represents not merely an augmentation of infrastructure but a qualitative enhancement of the justice delivery system, instilling renewed confidence among the litigants, CJI said
- » Justice Palli expressed optimism regarding continued support for the expansion and modernisation of judicial infrastructure in the region
- » L-G Saxena conveyed his appreciation to the CJI for facilitating the inauguration

stands as a symbol of resilience.

The new complex represents not merely an augmentation of infrastructure but a qualitative enhancement of the justice delivery system, instilling renewed confidence among the litigants, he said.

The proceedings commenced with the national song and national anthem, followed by the unveiling and formal

reading of the commemorative plaque, an official spokesman said.

A comprehensive 3D presentation showcased the architecture and facilities of the complex, including courtrooms, administrative offices and residential quarters, he said.

Justice Palli expressed optimism regarding continued support for the expansion and

modernisation of judicial infrastructure in the region.

L-G Saxena conveyed his appreciation to the CJI for facilitating the inauguration, saying the occasion carried profound significance.

Characterising the complex as a symbol of the government's commitment to accessible and effective justice, Saxena assured full administrative support to

the judiciary.

The president of the Kargil Bar Association, Riyaz Ahmed Khan, conveyed his gratitude to the CJI and the administration, and described the moment as the fulfilment of a long-pending demand. He also expressed confidence that the new complex would substantially strengthen the justice delivery system in the district.

ASSAM POLLS 2026

# Deploying forest guards ‘concerning’, say wildlife conservationists

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A group of former bureaucrats and wildlife conservationists has called for the retraction of an order from the Assam government's environment department requiring the deployment of about 1,600 Assam Forest Protection Force (AFPF) personnel for the upcoming elections in the state.

In an open letter, the officials state that the deployment of AFPF will not only undermine forest and wildlife protection but also be in direct contravention of established legal and administrative norms. “As per the explicit guidelines of the Election Commission of India (ECI), territorial forest forces and serving forest officials, including senior Indian Forest Service (IFS) officers, are not to be requisitioned for election-related duties,” said the letter.

Written by Prakriti Srivastava, former principal chief conservator of forests (PCCF),



The personnel are required to report to Assam's Additional Director General of Police (ADGP) by April 3 and are expected to return on April 10

Kerala, the letter has also been signed by Meena Gupta, former secretary of the Environment Ministry, Dr AK Jha, former PCCF, Maharashtra, Dr Uma Shankar Singh, former PCCF, Uttar Pradesh, Prerna Singh Bindra, former mem-

ber of the National Board of Wildlife's standing committee, and Debadipto Sinha, a wildlife conservationist.

The letter also cites a 2024 Supreme Court order that exempted forest officials and departmental vehicles from election deployment.

“This matter requires urgent attention to prevent administrative overreach and to uphold the rule of law, while ensuring that our forests, wildlife and their habitats are protected and not allowed to be plundered by unscrupulous elements in the absence of field staff,” said the letter.

Issued on March 19, the order by Assam's environment department directed the deployment of AFPF personnel to assist the state police for the elections, which are scheduled to take place on April 9.

The personnel are required to report to Assam's Additional Director General of Police (ADGP) by April 3 and are expected to return on April 10.

# Centre okays 100 school herbal gardens for Jammu

OUR CORRESPONDENT

JAMMU: In a major push to promote awareness and conservation of medicinal plants, the National Medicinal Plants Board under the Union Ministry of Ayush has approved a Rs 53 lakh project to establish 100 School Herbal Gardens across Jammu, an official spokesperson said on Sunday.

The initiative envisages the development of herbal gardens in selected schools, with 10 schools to be covered in each district of the division, the spokesperson said.

He said the project has been approved after recommendations from the Directorate of Ayush, J&K (J&K Medicinal Plants Board), with the objective of integrating the rich heritage of medicinal plants into the school education system in a meaningful and practical

manner.

The herbal gardens will serve as vibrant learning spaces where the students will gain first-hand knowledge about the identification, cultivation and uses of important medicinal plants, while also developing a deeper appreciation for nature and traditional systems of healthcare, the spokesperson said.

He said 100 schools have been identified by the Directorate of School Education, Jammu.

Director Ayush, J&K and CEO, J&K Medicinal Plants Board, Ajay Kumar Tikoo, termed the approval as a significant milestone and expressed confidence that these herbal gardens will evolve into centres of experiential learning and inspire students to actively engage with nature and wellness practices.

# Court orders issuance of summons against former DGP over inaction on MHADA fraud complaint

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: A sessions court in Mumbai has directed a magistrate to issue summonses to former Maharashtra director general of police Satish Mathur and other senior officers for not registering an FIR against MHADA officials in a complaint of alleged fraud.

After issuing summonses, the magistrate has been directed to proceed further against the officers by recording evidence of the complainant and witnesses.

Additional Sessions Judge Mujibodeen S Shaikh, earlier this month, had overturned a magistrate court order that dismissed a complaint against former top brass of the Anti Corruption Bureau (ACB), including its then head Mathur.

Judge Shaikh pulled up the officers for keeping the complaint pending for over

two years under the “garb of inquiry”, while waiting for opinions from the very government departments they were meant to investigate.

The court found that the act of the officers came under “the omission to consider the prevailing laws and another facet of negligence or dereliction of duty”.

When there was ample evidence that MHADA officials in collusion with the developers caused wrongful loss to the government, then it was the duty of respondents to register the FIR immediately, the court said.

“Now the time has also come to make it clear that no one is above the law and law does not protect the white collar persons who are using their office/designation to protect the officers deeply involved in wrongful gain for them and wrongful loss for the state,” the

judge said in the order.

The order passed by the magistrate was “skin saving and erroneous” and needs to be quashed and set aside, Judge Shaikh said.

The matter pertains to a complaint filed by activist Kamalakar Shenoy in 2017 alleging a fraud involving the Maharashtra Housing and Area Development Authority (MHADA) and private developers.

As per Shenoy's complaint, private developers had failed to surrender surplus area measuring over 1,37,000 square metres to the state, causing wrongful gain of approximately Rs 14,000 crore to the developers and a corresponding loss to the public exchequer.

Shenoy claimed MHADA and police officials “wilfully and deliberately” failed to register a First Information Report (FIR) despite evidence of a cognizable offence.

Citing a Supreme Court order, the court ruled that if a complaint discloses a cognizable offence, police have no option but to register an FIR immediately.

“In the case in hand, the respondents (officers) have shown disregard to the mandate of law laid down in the above case law,” it held.

The court underlined that anti-corruption laws have been enacted, but effective and efficient implementation is lacking on account of the fact that corrupt activities are widespread in public administration.

The court then directed the magistrate to restore the complaint and issue process against the officials under sections 166A (public servant disobeying direction under law), 217 (shielding an accused), and 218 (creating fake or incorrect report) and 34 (common intention).

## From Page 1

## Iran warns US

ground invasion, including among Republicans.

Israel and the US are “working in very close coordination” to respond after Yemen's Houthis rebels said they had launched missiles toward Israeli targets, Israeli military spokesperson Col. Nadav Shoshani told reporters on Sunday.

He declined to provide details on operations against the Iran-backed group, which controls parts of Yemen, but said Israel had grown accustomed to confronting repeated attacks from the Houthis, who have for more than two years launched missiles and drones toward Israel and shipping targets in the Red Sea.

He also said Israeli military statements about nearing completion of top-priority strikes did not mean it was running out of overall targets.

Iran warned of additional escalation after Israeli airstrikes hit several universities, including ones that Israel claimed were used for nuclear research and development.

The paramilitary Revolutionary Guard warned in a statement that Iran would consider Israeli universities and branches of American universities in the region “legitimate targets” unless offered safety assurances for Iranian universities, state media reported.

American colleges, including Georgetown, New York University and Northwestern, have campuses in Qatar and the United Arab Emirates.

“If the US government wants its universities in the region spared, it should condemn the bombardment of (Iranian) universities by 12 o'clock Monday, March 30, in an official statement,” the Guard said.

It also demanded that the US stop Israel from striking Iranian universities and research centres. Iranian Foreign Ministry

spokesperson Esmail Baqaei said on Saturday that dozens of universities and research centres have been hit, among them the Iran University of Science and Technology and Isfahan University of Technology.

An adviser to the United Arab Emirates has called for any settlement to the war in the Middle East to include “clear guarantees” that Iranian attacks on its neighbours won't be repeated. In a social media post, Anwar Gargash said the Iran government has become “the main threat” to the Persian Gulf security.

Meanwhile, the UAE said its air defence systems are responding to more missile and drone attacks. The defence ministry said sounds heard across the country on Sunday were from interception efforts.

The UAE faced attacks from 16 missiles and 42 drones in the past 24 hours, according to the ministry.

Houthi Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree said on the rebels' Al-Masirah satellite television station on Saturday that they launched missiles toward “sensitive Israeli military sites” in the south.

The group — which controls parts of Yemen — launched repeated attacks aimed at Israel and Red Sea shipping during the height of the Israel-Hamas war. Israeli strikes on Yemen last year killed the rebel-run government's prime minister and top military general.

If the Houthis again increased attacks on commercial shipping, it would further push up oil prices and destabilise “all of maritime security”, said Ahmed Nagi, a senior Yemen analyst at the International Crisis Group. “The impact would not be limited to the energy market.”

Bab el-Mandeb, at the southern tip of the Arabian Peninsula, is crucial for vessels heading to the Suez Canal through the Red Sea. Saudi Arabia has been routing millions of barrels of crude oil a day through it because the Strait of Hormuz is effectively closed.

Iranian authorities say more

than 1,900 people have been killed in the Islamic Republic, while 19 have been reported dead in Israel.

In Lebanon, where Israel has started an invasion in the south while targeting the Hezbollah militant group, officials said more than 1,100 people have been killed in the country since the start of the war.

## PM warns against

Today, through ‘Mann Ki Baat’, I would once again urge all my countrymen that we must unitedly overcome this challenge,” PM Modi said.

Those who are politicising this issue should refrain from doing so as this is a matter concerning the interests of 140 crore citizens. There is no place for self-serving politics, he said.

“I would also appeal to all citizens to remain vigilant and not be misled by rumours. Trust only the continuous information provided by the government and take action based only on that,” he added.

As always, Modi said, he was confident that just as the people of the country have overcome past crises with their collective strength, this time too, “we will together emerge victorious from this difficult situation”.

He said millions of Indian family members live in these Gulf countries and are working there. “I am deeply grateful to the Gulf countries, which are providing all kinds of assistance to more than 1 crore such Indians living there,” he said.

The PM said West Asia is a major centre of India's energy needs and on account of that, a crisis is emerging around the world regarding petrol and diesel.

“Our global relations, the support we receive from various countries and the strengths the country has built over the past decade have enabled India to bravely confront these circumstances,” he said.

At the outset of this address,

Modi said the month of March has been full of turbulence globally. He said all citizens of the country remember that the entire world faced myriad problems for a long time on account of Covid.

“Indeed, all of us had expected that after emerging from the Corona crisis, the world would move forward on the path of renewed progress,” Modi said.

However, he said, situations of war and conflict have continuously arisen in different parts of the world.

Speaking at a largely attended NDA election rally in Palakkad in poll-bound Kerala, PM Modi said his government is working to limit the impact of the West Asia war on India, while accusing the Congress of making “dangerous” remarks that could put Indians living in the Gulf at risk for political gain.

Modi said many people from Kerala are working in conflict-hit regions and stressed that their safety remains a top priority.

“At this time, everyone's attention is on the war going on in West Asia. Our government is continuously working to ensure that its impact on India is minimal,” he said, in an apparent reference to the safety of Indians living in the Gulf and India's dependence on crude oil and gas from conflict-affected regions.

Highlighting ongoing diplomatic efforts, Modi added, “Since the beginning of the war, I have been in constant touch with the heads of all these countries. All nations are giving priority to the safety of Indians stranded in the conflict zones.”

He said Indian embassies are working round the clock to support citizens abroad.

“To ensure that our brothers and sisters there do not face any hardship, Indian embassies are also working day and night. The protection of Indians' interests is the top priority for the BJP-NDA government,” he said.

Targeting the Congress in poll-bound Kerala, from where lakhs of people work in Gulf countries, the Prime Minister said, “You must also remember

the kind of statements the Congress is making on this sensitive issue -- they are dangerous.”

“Congress wants the lives of nearly one crore Indians living in Gulf countries to be put at risk, so that it can gain political advantage from it,” Modi said.

Modi's statement comes days after Congress leader Rahul Gandhi attacked his government's handling of the West Asia crisis.

## Bihar CM may resign

development, stating that party workers had opposed the decision but Kumar remained firm. “Everyone wanted the same, but he did not agree,” Singh said in remarks shared with ANI.

The development comes amid political debate over Kumar's transition to national politics. Rashtriya Janata Dal leader Tejashwi Yadav alleged that Kumar was reluctant to leave the chief minister's post and was pressured by ally Bharatiya Janata Party.

“He had no wish to relinquish the post,” Yadav said, adding that the BJP aimed to weaken the JD(U). Kumar has not publicly responded to these claims. AGENCIES

## Govt may consider

as steep freight hikes, rising insurance premiums and war-related risks.

The scheme is expected to help maintain supply chain stability, support MSME exporters, reduce the likelihood of order cancellations and protect employment in export-oriented sectors.

In a further boost, the government restored full benefits under the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products scheme. The Directorate General of Foreign Trade stated in a notification that “the RoDTEP rates and value caps as specified as applicable on February 22, 2026, are hereby restored with effect from Febru-

ary 23, 2026 to March 31, 2026 for all eligible export products.” The move reverses last month's decision to halve duty benefits, which had drawn concerns from exporters.

Economic policymakers have acknowledged the broader risks posed by the conflict. Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran said India would need to extend immediate support to the most affected businesses and households while also creating fiscal space for long-term priorities.

“This calls for re-prioritisation of spending and targeted relief for the most affected and vulnerable businesses and households,” he said in the latest Monthly Economic Review released on Saturday.

The review noted that the economic impact of recent global shocks is being transmitted through higher input costs, supply constraints and sector-wide pressures, with early signs of moderation in economic activity. It warned that the near-term outlook remains uncertain, with external disruptions posing risks to growth.

At the same time, it pointed to strong macroeconomic fundamentals and resilient domestic demand as factors that could help cushion the impact. However, the report underlined that the evolving geopolitical situation presents layered challenges for India, given its energy dependence and deep trade, investment and remittance ties with the West Asia region.

## Incarceration

It set aside the July 11, 2025, order of the Punjab and Haryana High Court rejecting Kumar's bail plea.

“Prosecution proposes to examine 23 witnesses to drive home the charges against the appellant, but none has been examined. Thus, the trial is likely to take some time to conclude,” the bench said in its March 13 order.

It added that almost two years have passed since Kumar was arrested, without a trial having commenced and a conclusion

thereof nowhere in sight.

“Incarceration without trial amounts to punishment,” the bench highlighted.

Taking an overall view of the matter, the court was of the considered opinion that further detention of the appellant pending trial is not necessary; and, since the appeal deserves acceptance, the appellant may be admitted to an order for the grant of bail, it said.

Imposing conditions on Kumar, the bench said he shall be released on bail, subject to furnishing of bail bonds to the satisfaction of the trial court and subject to such other terms and conditions as may be imposed by it.

“Needless to observe, the appellant shall not, directly or indirectly, by making inducement, threat or promise, dissuade any person acquainted with the facts of the case from disclosing such facts to the court,” it said.

In the event there is any breach of the terms and conditions for the grant of bail, the trial court shall be at liberty to cancel the bail of the appellant, it added.

The top court, while allowing the appeal, directed Kumar to diligently attend proceedings of the trial, unless exempted.

“If he abstains from attending the proceedings without justifiable cause, that could also be seen as a breach of the conditions for grant of bail and the trial court will be free to pass appropriate orders,” it said.

The bench further said the observations made in this order and grant of bail will not be treated as findings on the merits of the case.

## Telangana

fine of Rs 1 lakh. The Bill defines hate speech broadly, including expressions that incite hatred or disharmony based on religion, caste, gender, language, or other identities. It also holds organisations accountable, allows removal of offensive digital content, and classifies offences as cognizable and non-bailable.



SLAMS LDF, UDF AS 'LOOTERS'

# PM Modi vows NDA govt in Kerala after April 9 Assembly election

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**PALAKKAD:** In a high-voltage rally here on Sunday ahead of the 9 April polls, Prime Minister Narendra Modi tore into both the CPI(M)-led LDF and the Congress-led UDF, accusing them of “looting” Kerala and declaring that the BJP-led NDA is the state’s “real A-team”, not anyone’s “B-team”.

Instilling confidence among BJP workers, who have faced an electoral drought ever since the formation of the saffron party four decades ago, Modi asserted that the NDA would form the next government in Kerala.

“In Kerala, Team BJP and Team NDA are to form the government. With the blessings of the people of Kerala, and with all your support, we will form the government here, and we will leave no stone unturned in serving Kerala,” he said.

Promising to fulfil Modi’s



Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a public meeting, ahead of the Kerala Assembly elections, in Palakkad

PTI

guarantee in Kerala if voted to power, the PM said he could sense a changing political atmosphere in the state, indicating growing support for the BJP-led alliance.

“There is a different atmosphere in Kerala, sending a message of change,” he said.

Modi claimed that the NDA and the BJP are witnessing

increasing acceptance among various sections of society.

“Now, the youth of Kerala have faith in the BJP and the NDA. Now, the women of Kerala have affection for the BJP and the NDA. Now, the farmers of Kerala have love for the BJP and the NDA,” he said.

Launching a scathing attack on both fronts, he alleged that

HIGHLIGHTS

» PM Modi claimed that the NDA and the BJP are witnessing increasing acceptance among various sections of society

» ‘Now, the youth of Kerala have faith in the BJP and the NDA’

the LDF and the UDF have alternated in power while “looting” the state.

“There has been a practical understanding between them -- for a few years the LDF runs the government and fills its pockets, and after that the UDF comes and continues the loot. In this arrangement, Kerala has remained trapped,” he said.

He said both the Left and the Congress accuse each other of being the BJP’s “B-team”.

“This means that both the

LDF and the UDF have themselves admitted that in this Kerala election, if there is one real A-team, it is only and only the BJP,” he said.

Modi said both fronts are targeting the BJP out of fear.

“This means that if these two corrupt parties are afraid of anyone, it is the BJP. They fear the BJP because they believe that if the BJP comes to power, all their wrongdoings will be exposed,” he said.

He alleged that successive LDF and UDF governments have been involved in major scams and failed to act against each other.

“If a BJP government comes to power, it will investigate every scam of the LDF and the UDF and ensure justice for the people of Kerala,” he said.

Modi also claimed that the Congress and the Left are allies in several states across the country but present themselves as rivals in Kerala.

## ‘Environment of hatred, atrocities intensified in Guj’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday alleged that the environment of hatred, discrimination and atrocities against the Dalit and Adivasi communities in Gujarat has steadily intensified under the BJP government.

The leader of Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha also expressed solidarity with the victims of the 2016 Una flogging case and vowed to continue to amplify their voices until justice is served.

Gandhi made the remarks on social media while putting out a video of his recent interaction with a delegation of representatives from the Dalit and Adivasi communities from Gujarat, including those affected by the Una incident, in which

CLOSER LOOK

» Rahul expressed solidarity with the victims of the 2016 Una flogging case

» Gandhi made the

remarks on social media while putting out a video of his recent interaction with Dalit and Adivasi communities from Gujarat

self-proclaimed cow vigilantes flogged four youths.

“This meeting was deeply distressing and gave me much pause for reflection,” he said in his post accompanied by the video.

The flogging incident had occurred in Mota Samadhiya village near Una town of Gir-Somnath district on July 11, 2016, when four Dalit youths, as part of their traditional profession, were skinning the carcass of a cow that had died earlier in some other village.

## ANNOUNCES CONG’S ‘5 GUARANTEES’

# Assam polls: Kharge pledges monthly cash transfer to women

**NAOBOICHA:** Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday announced his party’s “five guarantees” for poll-bound Assam, with a focus on women’s welfare, healthcare for all, land rights and justice in the Zubeen Garg death case.

He also took a swipe at the BJP-led government in the state, accusing it of indulging in rampant corruption and working “to fill the coffers” of its leaders in Delhi and their families.

Addressing a rally at Nao-boicha in Lakhimpur district, Kharge listed the party’s “five guarantees”, which include an unconditional monthly money transfer into every woman’s



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge being felicitated during a public meeting, in Nao-boicha

PTI

bank account, along with an additional Rs 50,000 assistance to women willing to set up or expand a business.

“Our transfer will be unconditional. It will not be like what the BJP government

is doing, where women are asked to be members of their party,” he said.

The Congress, which is looking to wrest power from the BJP in the state, pledged Rs 25 lakh cashless health insurance for all families, permanent land pattas for 10 lakh indigenous people and Rs 1,250 per month for senior citizens of the state.

A dedicated department will also be established to oversee matters concerning the elderly, Kharge said.

“We also pledge to ensure justice in the Zubeen Garg death case within 100 days of Congress coming to power,” he added.

MPOST

## TAMIL NADU POLLS

# DMK promises Rs 8K ‘Illatharasi’ coupon scheme for women

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**CHENNAI:** Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and DMK president M K Stalin on Sunday released his party’s manifesto for the April 23 Assembly elections, and announced providing the “Illatharasi” coupon scheme worth Rs 8,000 for women to buy/replace household electronic goods.

He promised to implement a number of welfare measures in different sectors including education, industry and farming should the DMK return to power and described his party’s set of poll promises as a “superstar”.

He said the coupon for women could be used to buy household appliances like TV, refrigerator, washing machine, mixer, microwave oven, induction stove or replace them.

“This new Illatharasi scheme will be implemented. Under this scheme, the women of families who don’t come under the income tax bracket would be provided a one-time coupon worth Rs 8,000 to purchase these electronic goods from the shops

UCC in the state if he became chief minister after the Assembly polls.

The state has already passed an anti-polygamy bill, making it an offence which may lead to a maximum of 10 years of imprisonment, barring some exceptions. Uttarakhand is the first state in the country to implement UCC.

At the poll rallies, Shah alleged that infiltrators had taken away the employment of the indigenous Assamese youth and seized the foodgrains of the poor.

He accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of opposing the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in several states to “protect infiltrators”. “We will not let this happen.”

The Election Commission of India is trying to weed out infiltrators from the electoral rolls, and the Congress is trying to stop it, Shah claimed.

“But the BJP government will detect each one of them, delete their names from the electoral rolls and deport them back to the country from where they came,” he asserted.

## LS to discuss govt’s efforts to end Naxal problem today

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The Lok Sabha will discuss efforts to free the country from left-wing extremism (LWE) on Monday, a day before the government’s March 31 deadline to eliminate Naxalism ends.

The Lok Sabha Secretariat has listed the discussion on “efforts to free the country from left-wing extremism” for Monday under Rule 193, which does not entail voting. The short-duration discussion under the rule requires a reply by the government.

The discussion will be initiated by TDP MP Byreddy Shabari and Shiv Sena member Shrikant Shinde.

Union Home minister Amit Shah had announced that the Naxal menace would be completely eliminated by March 31, 2026.

A fresh review of the Naxal violence affected regions has brought down the number of LWE-hit districts in the country to seven from eight.

A comprehensive review of the ‘National Policy and Action Plan to address LWE’ was undertaken recently by the Union government with nine states comprising 38 districts.

These states are Jharkhand, Bihar, Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Telangana and West Bengal.

Security forces deployed in the anti-Naxal operations grid had launched a mega operation to neutralise the remaining armed Maoist cadres ahead of the March 31 deadline.



DMK chief and TN Chief Minister MK Stalin during the release of the party’s manifesto for the upcoming state Assembly elections, in Chennai

PTI

in their places of residence,” Stalin said.

“Illatharasi” in Tamil literally translates to the “queen of the house,” and in effect refers to a women head of the family.

Announcing a slew of welfare measures targeting women, girl students, farmers and fishermen, he said “I have mentioned a few as a highlight.”

“Usually in Tamil Nadu elections the DMK election manifesto is the hero, but now Dravidian model 2.0’s poll manifesto is the superstar,” Stalin, who is confident of winning over 200 seats out of 234 in the April 23 election, said.

## TN: Vijay to contest from Perambur, Trichy East

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**CHENNAI:** TVK chief Vijay on Sunday named his party’s candidates for all 234 Assembly constituencies in Tamil Nadu for the April 23 elections, announcing his electoral debut from two seats, including Perambur in Chennai, considered a DMK stronghold.

In his maiden electoral battle, Vijay will also contest from Tiruchirappalli (East) in central Tamil Nadu.

“It will be C Joseph Vijay from these two seats,” the actor-turned-politician announced emphatically amid loud cheers at a meeting of party functionaries held at a five-star hotel in the city.

On the occasion, he also named and introduced nominees for the remaining 232 seats, including members of his core team.

Reiterating that the electoral contest was between his “people’s alliance TVK” and the “Stalin-led alliance”, he described the ruling DMK-led bloc as a “patch-up”.

“I have selected candidates who will stand with the people,” he said.

“They are not mere ‘vetpalar-gal’ (candidates), but ‘makkal kappalargal’ (people’s protectors),” Vijay said, urging voters to extend wholehearted support to them.

He particularly exhorted Gen Z voters to turn out in large numbers for the party’s ‘whistle’ symbol and encourage their families to back TVK candidates.

“This is a generational electoral battle,” he said, claiming the contest was primarily between the DMK and TVK.

Outlining the qualities of an MLA, Vijay said they must possess impeccable integrity and should not “loot” the people.

Unveiling a youth-focused agenda, which he termed a “guarantee”, Vijay promised several measures, including steps towards a drug-free Tamil Nadu and collateral-free loans of up to Rs 20 lakh for students from class 12 to PhD.

## Akhilesh counters Modi’s airport rally with sharp attack on BJP

Launches SP’s western UP push from Dadri

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

**DADRI:** A day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi mounted a strong political offensive following the inauguration of the Noida International Airport, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday responded with an equally aggressive show of strength in Dadri, formally kicking off his party’s campaign for the upcoming Assembly elections in the politically crucial western Uttar Pradesh belt.

The ‘Samajwadi Samanata Bhaichara’ rally marked the party’s first major mobilisation in the region, which holds significant electoral weight with

dozens of districts and over a hundred Assembly constituencies shaping the outcome of state politics.

By choosing Dadri, located close to the newly inaugurated airport, the Samajwadi Party sought to directly counter the narrative set by the BJP leadership a day earlier.

Addressing a packed gathering, Akhilesh Yadav projected confidence about the party’s momentum, pointing to the large turnout as evidence of public support.

He said the enthusiasm visible at the rally reflected a growing mood for change and credited local party leader Raj-

kumar Bhati for the mobilisation. The venue, dominated by red hues of the party flag, symbolised what he described as a resurgence of the Samajwadi base in the region.

Launching a pointed attack on the BJP without naming it directly, Akhilesh alleged that the ruling party was rattled by the scale of the Samajwadi Party’s preparations.

He claimed that the publicity around Sunday’s rally had forced the BJP to organise its own event a day earlier. He further alleged that attendance at that rally was artificially managed, with people being brought in rather than participating voluntarily.

## ‘TOXIC TOURIST DESTINATION’

# Scenic marble waste site in Rajasthan draws visitors, experts flag health hazard

MPOST BUREAU

**KISHANGARH:** Endless white plains glowing under the sun, no pine trees, no chill in the air, yet the scenery looks straight out of a winter postcard. Many confuse it for Bolivia’s Salt Flats, snow-clad Gulmarg or even scenic Switzerland.

This picturesque location, which has become a popular reel destination, is Asia’s largest marble waste dumping yard in Kishangarh in Ajmer district of arid Rajasthan.

The dumping site, where over 700 tankers carrying around 22 lakh litres of marble slurry are emptied every day, attracts at least 5,000 visitors on a daily basis, with the footfall going up to 20,000 on weekends and holidays.

Due to its pristine white appearance, the dumping yard, spread over 350 acres, has also become a popular destination for pre-wedding and commercial shoots. Environmentalists and health experts, however, have flagged it as not just a health hazard but also a pollution hotspot.



People pose for photographs at the marble waste dumping yard, in Kishangarh, Rajasthan, Wednesday

PTI

Scientific studies conducted by the Central University of Rajasthan have flagged it as a “toxic tourist destination”, documenting the health and ecological impacts of this unregulated dumping. The concerns also reached the National Green Tribunal (NGT), which set up a joint committee including members from state and central pollution control boards.

“Despite its scale and impact, the dumping yard is being operated in rampant violation of basic

environmental safeguards. There is no engineered liner system, no decanting wells, no dust suppression mechanisms, no monitoring of air or groundwater, and no protective green belt.

“These failures have led to severe contamination of groundwater, degradation of agricultural land and high levels of fugitive dust pollution, thereby endangering public health,” Laxmi Kant Sharma, Environ-

mental Science professor at Central University of Rajasthan, told

KEY POINTS

» This picturesque location, which has become a popular reel destination, is Asia’s largest marble waste dumping yard

» Due to its pristine white appearance, the dumping yard also become a popular destination for pre-wedding and commercial shoots

news agency.

Sharma noted that the university’s studies have found that the toxic contamination of water sources in the vicinity is reflected in total dissolved solid escalating 10 times above the safe limit in a 6-km radius of the dumping site.

“The concentration of lead silicate in soil and nitrate and fluoride concentrations in water were found several times higher than normal levels, indicating extreme contamination. Our study also found that the con-



'MOST STRATEGICALLY SIGNIFICANT'

# Defence cooperation key pillar of India-US ties: Ambassador Sergio Gor

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: US Ambassador Sergio Gor has underlined that defence and security cooperation remains the cornerstone of the India-US partnership, describing it as the "most strategically significant" area of collaboration even as both countries expand economic and technological ties.

In an interview to Span magazine, the US embassy publication, the envoy highlighted the deepening military engagement between New Delhi and Washington, pointing to growing interoperability, joint exercises and defence sales as key pillars of the relationship.

"India is a major defence partner, and defence cooperation is one of the brightest spots in our bilateral relationship. We also strengthen US-India military interoperability through participation in military exercises such as Malabar, Tiger Triumph and Cope India," he said.

Emphasising the strategic alignment between the two nations, Gor added: "Both of our nations are also part of the Quad, a strategic partnership that keeps our security interests robust and aligned. These three core aspects -- diplomacy, defence exercises and military sales -- ensure strong, continued defence cooperation. If these aspects are maintained, I predict a natural strengthening of our defence ties."

His remarks come at a time when both countries are seeking to reinforce ties after a brief period of strain linked to US tariff policies, with renewed focus on strengthening defence coordination in the Indo-Pacific region.



In this image posted on X on Feb 20, 2026, US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor speaks during an event announcing India joining the Pax Silica initiative, in New Delhi

PTI

## HIGHLIGHTS

» His remarks come at a time when both countries are seeking to reinforce ties after a brief period of strain linked to US tariff policies

» Gor also stressed that security cooperation is closely linked to broader geopolitical and economic stability

Gor, a close aide of Donald Trump, also stressed that security cooperation is closely linked to broader geopolitical and economic stability. Without naming specific threats, he said the US remains committed to working with partners like India to combat terrorism, violent radicalisation and transnational crime, noting that security and economic prosperity are "intertwined".

"My vision is to transform the US-India relationship into the defining strategic partner-

ship of the 21st century, one that delivers tangible benefits for both our nations," he said.

Alongside defence ties, the ambassador highlighted expanding cooperation in critical technologies and supply chains that have direct implications for national security. He noted that both countries are prioritising resilient supply chains for semiconductors and critical minerals under frameworks such as the US-India COMPACT initiative.

"I'm pleased to report that these prospects are exceptionally strong. For example, the US-India COMPACT framework prioritises building resilient supply chains for semiconductors, critical minerals, and pharmaceuticals," he said.

Referring to India joining the US-led Pax Silica initiative, Gor said, "Pax Silica is focused on further aligning US-India economic and national security interests through partnerships on critical mineral processing capacity and AI infrastructure investments."

'MUKH MANTRI MAWAN DHEEYAN SATKAR YOJNA'

# Punjab okays Rs 1K/month aid for women

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The Punjab Cabinet on Sunday approved the 'Mukh Mantri Mawan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna', under which women will receive a monthly financial assistance of Rs 1,000, while those belonging to the Scheduled Castes will get Rs 1,500 a month.

The scheme will benefit more than 97 per cent of women in Punjab, an official statement said, sharing details of the decisions taken at the Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann. The scheme was a key poll promise of the ruling AAP in the run-up to the 2022 Punjab elections, which has been launched now, a year before the state goes to the polls again.

Under the scheme, women aged 18 years or more, who are registered as voters in the state with a valid Aadhaar card reflecting Punjab residency and a valid Voter ID issued by the

## INSIGHT

» 'The scheme will benefit more than 97 per cent of women in the state'

» The scheme has been designed as a direct benefit transfer initiative

Election Commission, shall be eligible as beneficiaries.

Addressing an event in Fatehgarh Sahib on Saturday, AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal had said, "With this scheme, we have fulfilled all our guarantees (promises made at the time of 2022 Punjab polls)."

The statement quoting the chief minister's office (CMO) said the scheme will have a "monumental effect" on the upliftment of women by empowering them to become independent.

"It will give them choice and, clubbed with financial literacy, it will promote savings, thrift

and investment, enabling dignity in fulfilling their small desires," the statement said. The scheme has been designed as a direct benefit transfer (DBT) initiative, under which the financial assistance will be transferred directly into the bank accounts of the beneficiaries.

There is no restriction on the number of eligible women in a family who may avail the benefits under the scheme, and the existing social security pensioners will also continue to receive its full financial benefits in addition to their pensions, it said.

According to the statement, Rs 9,300 crore has already been sanctioned in the Budget for the financial year 2026-27, and, given the scale and outreach of the scheme, it is expected to become one of the largest women-centric social welfare initiatives undertaken by the Punjab government.

The Cabinet also gave its consent to amendments in the

policy for the conversion of leasehold industrial plots/sheds to freehold. Now, industrial plots mortgaged with banks or financial institutions shall be eligible for conversion to freehold, subject to the submission of a no-objection certificate (NOC) from the concerned bank and compliance with the prescribed safeguards. A conversion fee of 5 per cent shall be applicable where the current title documents do not contain any clause relating to unearned increase, irrespective of its presence in earlier title documents.

The Cabinet also gave its nod to introduce the Punjab Common Infrastructure (Regulation and Maintenance) Amendment Bill, 2026, to reform the Punjab Common Infrastructure (Regulation and Maintenance) Act, 2012, to strengthen the effectiveness, transparency and financial sustainability of special purpose vehicle (SPVs) for better management of industrial areas.

## Manipur: Mob sets 'NSCN(IM) office' on fire

MPOST BUREAU

IMPHAL: An office allegedly used by NSCN(IM) was set on fire by an irate mob in Manipur's Ukhrul district on Sunday. No casualty was reported.

The incident took place after four cadres of the banned outfit, NSCN Eastern Flank, were shot dead allegedly by members of a rival group in Kamjong district on Saturday.

Tension had been brewing in the Ukhrul district headquarters since Sunday morning after news of the killing spread.

A group of people went to the "office of NSCN(IM)" and alleged that members of the outfit were involved in the killing. They demanded immediate punishment for those involved. The situation soon turned worse, and the mob set fire to the structure, the officials said.

## Goa sex scandal: Two sisters among victims

PANAJI: Investigations into an alleged sex scandal involving a Goa councillor's son have shown that he exploited multiple victims, including two sisters, one of them a minor, police said on Sunday.

So far, four females, including the girlfriend of 20-year-old accused Soham Naik, have filed police complaints against him, they said.

The Crime Branch, which is investigating the case, has received statements from four females -- two of them minors -- who claimed that they were sexually exploited by Naik, son of a councillor from Curchoorem Municipal Council in Goa's Kushavati district, as per officials.

The Curchoorem police arrested Naik on March 22 for allegedly raping several girls and circulating their obscene videos.

## So far, 4 females have filed complaints against the accused

The action came after locals protested outside the the police station. The case was later handed over to the Crime Branch.

Attempts are underway to reach out to more potential victims, a senior official said.

The Crime Branch has sent Naik's mobile phone for forensic examination.

The accused has been booked under relevant sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, the Goa Children's Act, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Information Technology Act. AGENCIES

## Allahabad HC: Minor's age-check test 'illegal' if proper documents available

LUCKNOW: The Lucknow bench of Allahabad High Court has said that it is illegal to conduct a medical examination (ossification test) to determine a minor's age when certificates from a school, board, municipal corporation, municipality, or panchayat are available.

Holding this, the High Court set aside the orders of the Juvenile Justice Board and the Special POCSO Court and granted bail to a minor accused of molesting and threatening a 15-year-old girl.

A bench of Justice Manish Kumar passed the order on Saturday on a revision petition filed by a minor.

The case is from Pratapgarh district, where an FIR was lodged with Leelapur police station on March 11, 2025,

## 'School or board certificates should be considered first for determining age'

charging the minor under sections of the POCSO Act and Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

It was argued on behalf of the minor petitioner that he was under 16 years of age at the time of the incident.

His high school certificate mentioned his date of birth as January 1, 2010, while his primary school records stated his date of birth as May 13, 2009.

Despite this, the Juvenile Justice Board ordered a medical examination to determine his age, which was upheld by the appellate court of the

Special Judge, POCSO Act, Pratapgarh.

Both orders were challenged in a revision petition filed before the High Court.

The High Court said that, according to Section 94 of the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015, school or board certificates should be considered first for determining age.

Birth certificates issued by municipal corporations, municipalities, or panchayats should be considered next. Only in the absence of these documents, a medical examination can be conducted.

The High Court observed that both available documents showed that the accused petitioner was a minor and that ordering a medical examination was against the law. MPOST

## HP: Fresh snowfall in higher reaches

SHIMLA: Higher reaches of Kullu and Lahaul and Spiti districts in Himachal Pradesh received a fresh spell of snow on Sunday, while the middle and lower areas received intermittent rains.

The Shimla Met office on Sunday issued an orange warning of hailstorm, thunderstorm with lightning and gusty winds (speed 40-60 kmph) at isolated areas in Mandi, Kullu and Shimla districts on Monday and predicted a wet spell in the state till April 4. Keylog received 1 cm of snow and Gondla also received traces of it. Snowfall was also witnessed at the south portal of the Atal Tunnel in the suburbs of Manali, with several videos of tourists enjoying the snow widely circulating on the internet.

Small vehicles and two-wheelers are not permitted beyond Solang barrier in Manali due to the snowfall and the local administration has urged the people to avoid travelling to higher reaches unless necessary and use 4x4 vehicles to stay safe.

Kangra with 18.5 mm of rain was the wettest in the state, followed by Solan 18.4 mm, Manali and Jot 15 mm each, Dharamshala 9.3 mm, Bharmaur 8.7 mm, Bhattiyat and Ghamroor 8.4 mm each, Bhuntar 8.2 mm, Kalpa 5.4 mm, Guler 5.2 mm, Nagrota Surian 4.8 mm, Aghar 4.6 mm and Shimla and Joggindernagar 4 mm each.

Thunderstorm and lightning were observed in Kangra and Jot, while gusty winds ranging between 37-39 km lashed Tabo and Seobagh. A fresh Western Disturbance is likely to affect northwest India from April 2, the weather office added.

Tabo was coldest at night with a low of 3.1 degrees Celsius. There was an appreciable fall in the maximum temperatures and Una was the hottest during the day with a high of 28.6 degrees Celsius. This month, Himachal Pradesh has received 87.4 mm of rain so far, 20 per cent less than the normal 108.8 mm. MPOST

## Sonipat: Haryana CM announces development projects for Gohana

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday announced several development initiatives for the Gohana Assembly constituency in Sonipat district, reaffirming the government's commitment to inclusive growth and infrastructure expansion.

Addressing a gathering at the 'Dhanyavaad Evam Vikas Rally' in Gohana, Saini announced the construction of a sports stadium in the constituency. He said that Bhagwan Parshuram Virasat Park, along with a jogging track, will be developed over Drain No. 8, according to a statement.

A multi-storey parking facility along with commercial space will also be established on a PPP mode, subject to the availability of land.

In the healthcare and education sector, he announced the set-



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini being felicitated by Cooperation minister Arvind Sharma with a memento during a rally in Gohana

MPOST

ting up of a Cardio Cath Lab on PPP mode at Bhagat Phool Singh Government Medical College, Khanpur Kalan.

He also stated that classes of the Physiotherapy College at the same institution will commence from the academic session 2027-28 after completion

of the building.

Saini, while addressing the public meeting organised by Cooperation minister Arvind Sharma, made several key announcements aimed at strengthening civic and other infrastructure, an official statement said. These include the construction of Shiv Dham on Sonipat Road, subject to land availability, the establishment of a new 33 KV substation at Power House Meham Road in Gohana, and the upgradation of the 33 KV substation at Khanpur Kalan.

He also stated that a tourism resort will be established in Gohana, subject to the availability of two acres of land by the gram panchayat. A Transport Nagar will also be developed by Haryana Shahari Vikas Pradhikaran, and plots will be allocated for social institutions in the upcoming HSPV sectors.

## PM Modi's vision transformed aviation, made air travel accessible to all: MP CM

Indore Airport's Terminal-1 inaugurated by CM Yadav & Civil Aviation minister Naidu

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Sunday credited Prime Minister Narendra Modi with ushering in a transformative phase in India's aviation sector, saying his "far-sighted vision" has made air travel accessible to every section of society.

Addressing a gathering at the inauguration of Terminal-1 at Devi Ahilyabai Holkar International Airport, Indore, Yadav said the Prime Minister's long-term approach and policy push have led to an unprecedented expansion of aviation infrastructure and connectivity across the country. "It is due to this visionary leadership that even people from modest backgrounds can now afford to travel by air," he said, underlining the democratisation of air travel.

Yadav also highlighted the launch of the PM Shri Air Ambulance Service in the state, which is helping critically ill patients reach higher medical centres swiftly.

The Chief Minister noted



that schemes aimed at enhancing regional connectivity and expanding airport infrastructure have significantly increased passenger footfall, while also bringing smaller cities onto the aviation map. He said the pace at which air services are growing in India today was "once unimaginable".

Highlighting Madhya Pradesh's alignment with the Centre's aviation push, Yadav said the state is rapidly expanding its own infrastructure to ensure wider access and improved connectivity, particularly for remote and underserved regions.

The CM described the

upgraded terminal as a major boost for Indore and the Malwa region. The airport has also received a quality certification from the American Quality Council, which Yadav presented to airport officials.

Union Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu joined the event virtually.

Before the terminal inauguration, CM Yadav along with Urban Development and Housing Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya listened to the 132nd edition of PM Modi's Mann Ki Baat monthly radio programme. The CM said the programme is an effective platform for the Prime

## KEY POINTS

» Yadav and Vijayvargiya listen to PM Modi's Mann Ki Baat, the monthly radio programme

» Indore receives quality certification from American Quality Council

Minister to connect with citizens, highlighting development and non-political issues while promoting unity and harmony.

An "Udaan Yatri Cafe" will also be introduced, offering tea at ₹10 and snacks at ₹20 to improve passenger convenience, the CM announced.

Yadav said MP now has eight airports, 20 airstrips, and 220 helipads, with new airports operational in Rewa, Satna, and Datia, and plans underway for Ujjain and Shivpuri. The government aims for a commercial airport every 150 km, an airstrip every 75 km, and a helipad every 45 km.

## Naxalite carrying Rs 5L bounty gunned down in Chhattisgarh

SUKMA: A Naxalite carrying a bounty of Rs 5 lakh was killed in an encounter with security personnel in Chhattisgarh's Sukma district on Sunday, two days before the March 31 deadline set by the Centre to eliminate Left Wing Extremism from the country, police said.

The gunfight occurred on a forested hill under the Polampalli police station area, where a team of the District Reserve Guard (DRG), a unit of the state police, was out on an anti-Naxal operation based on inputs about the presence of Maoists in the area, Sukma Superintendent of Police Kiran Chavan said.

Once the exchange of fire stopped, the body of a Naxalite, along with a weapon, was recovered from the spot, he said. The deceased, Muchaki Kailash, was the section commander of platoon no. 31 of Maoists and carried a bounty of Rs 5 lakh, the official said. MPOST

tisgarh, Jharkhand, Odisha, Maharashtra, and parts of Andhra Pradesh, where contractors refused to work.

The Centre tasked the Border Roads Organisation with building roads in People's Lib-

eration Guerrilla Army (PLGA) core areas, involving the construction of five key roads and six crucial bridges in these hotbeds of the insurgency.

More than 15,000 kilometres of roads have been con-

## RPF intensifies vigil, 37 held in March: NFR



MALIGAON: The Railway Protection Force (RPF) of Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) has intensified its vigilance, carrying out a series of successful operations across multiple stations and trains on March 24, officials said. Actions were conducted at key locations including Guwahati, New Jalpaiguri, Aluabari, Kamakhya, Hojai, Agartala, Samsi and New Bongaigaon.

At Guwahati station, RPF personnel rescued a minor boy from Train No. 15933 and handed him over to the Child Welfare Committee. In another operation, RPF and CIB teams apprehended a tout at Samsi with 14 illegal e-tickets worth over Rs 61,700. Contraband items such as ganja and liquor were also seized, along with arrests in arms possession and drugging cases. In March, RPF recovered narcotics and other items worth over Rs 1.93 crore and arrested 37 persons. MPOST

## Nation Briefs

### UP: MAN KILLS 12-YR-OLD DAUGHTER FOR 'STEALING' CANDY FROM GROCERY STORE

Bulandshahr (UP): Police on Sunday arrested a man for allegedly beating his 12-year-old daughter to death with a stick for "stealing" a packet of candy from a grocery store here, officials said. According to police, a complaint was lodged at Ratanpur village on March 27 by the girl's mother, Aarti, who alleged that her husband, Pushpendra alias Pappu Sharma, beat their daughter with a stick, leading to her death. Pushpendra was enraged after a local shopkeeper complained to him that his daughter had stolen a packet of candy from his shop, police said. Based on the complaint, police registered an FIR at the Narora police station and arrested Pushpendra on Sunday. "The stick used in the crime has been recovered at the instance of the accused," an official said.

### RAIN BRINGS DOWN MERCURY LEVELS IN PARTS OF HARYANA, PUNJAB

CHANDIGARH: Rain lashed parts of Punjab and Haryana on Sunday, leading to a drop in day temperatures at many places, the local weather office said. Chandigarh, the common capital of the two states, received light rain and recorded a maximum temperature of 27.3 degrees Celsius, down by more than four notches against the normal limits, the weather office said. Ambala, Panchkula and Yamunanagar in Haryana and Rupnagar, Mohali, Patiala, Phagwara, Jalandhar, Hoshiarpur and Ludhiana in Punjab were among places that received rain on Sunday.





EDITORIAL

SHRINKING F&O MARGINS

The revision of Securities Transaction Tax (STT) rates from April 1 marks yet another moment where policy intent, market behaviour, and investor psychology intersect in complex ways. While STT has always been positioned as a low-friction tax—easy to collect, difficult to evade—its incremental hikes, especially in the derivatives segment, signal a deeper regulatory nudge. The message is not merely fiscal; it is behavioural. At a time when India's equity markets are witnessing unprecedented retail participation, particularly in futures and options (F&O), the increase in STT appears designed to temper speculative excess without overtly restricting market access. Yet, as with most tax changes, the impact will not be uniform. It will be felt differently across long-term investors, short-term traders, and high-frequency participants who rely on razor-thin margins.

To understand the implications, it is important to revisit what is changing. The government has increased STT on the sale of options in the F&O segment, raising the effective cost of trading derivatives. Traditionally, STT on options was levied on the premium value, making it relatively low compared to the notional turnover involved. The revised structure increases this burden, particularly affecting traders who operate on high volumes. In contrast, STT rates on equity delivery trades remain largely unchanged, reinforcing a clear policy preference: discourage excessive speculation while preserving the attractiveness of long-term investing. This divergence between cash markets and derivatives is not accidental; it reflects concerns raised by regulators, including the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), about the growing dominance of retail investors in F&O trading—often with limited understanding of the risks involved.

For F&O traders, the hike is likely to have immediate and tangible consequences. Margins in derivatives trading are already compressed due to brokerage costs, exchange fees, and slippages. An increase in STT directly eats into profitability, particularly for intraday traders and those employing strategies such as scalping or arbitrage. For instance, strategies that depend on frequent entry and exit points will now face higher cumulative tax outflows, potentially rendering some of them unviable. This could lead to a shift in trading behaviour, with participants either reducing the frequency of trades or moving towards strategies with longer holding periods. In the short term, one might even see a decline in trading volumes in certain options contracts, especially among retail traders who are more sensitive to cost increases.

However, it would be simplistic to view the STT hike solely as a deterrent. There is also a stabilisation argument at play. Over the past few years, India's derivatives market has grown exponentially, often outpacing the underlying cash market in terms of turnover. This imbalance raises systemic concerns. When a large proportion of market activity is driven by leveraged bets rather than fundamental investing, volatility can amplify, and price discovery can become distorted. By making speculative trades marginally more expensive, the government and regulators may be attempting to restore a healthier balance between the cash and derivatives segments. In this sense, the STT hike can be interpreted as a soft intervention—one that nudges behaviour without imposing hard restrictions such as position limits or outright bans.

For long-term investors, the immediate impact is likely to be minimal. Since STT on delivery-based equity transactions remains unchanged, the cost structure for buy-and-hold strategies is largely intact. In fact, there is an indirect benefit. If the STT hike succeeds in curbing excessive speculative activity, it could lead to lower volatility and more stable price movements over time. This, in turn, may enhance investor confidence and encourage greater participation in the cash market. Additionally, a shift away from short-term trading towards long-term investing aligns with broader policy goals of channelling household savings into productive capital formation.

That said, there are legitimate concerns about unintended consequences. One of the risks is that higher transaction costs could push some traders towards less-regulated or offshore platforms where tax enforcement is weaker. While this may not be a large-scale shift, even a marginal migration of volume can have implications for market liquidity and transparency. Another concern is that frequent tax changes, even if incremental, create an environment of uncertainty. For market participants, especially institutional investors, predictability in tax policy is as important as the rates themselves. Sudden or frequent revisions can complicate strategy planning and risk assessment.

There is also a broader question about whether taxation is the most effective tool to address speculative excess. Behavioural change in markets is often driven as much by education and awareness as by cost structures. While increasing STT may discourage some forms of high-frequency trading, it does little to improve financial literacy among retail investors who enter the F&O segment with unrealistic expectations. A more holistic approach would combine calibrated taxation with stronger investor education initiatives, clearer risk disclosures, and perhaps even suitability frameworks that guide retail participation in complex derivatives products.

Ultimately, the STT hike from April 1 reflects a balancing act. On one hand, the government seeks to safeguard market stability and protect retail investors from excessive risk-taking. On the other hand, it must ensure that the cost of participation does not become prohibitive or distort market dynamics. The distinction between "old" and "new" tax rates is therefore more than a numerical change; it is a signal of policy direction. Whether this recalibration achieves its intended outcomes will depend on how market participants adapt. If it leads to more measured trading, improved risk management, and a renewed focus on fundamentals, the hike could be seen as a necessary correction. If, however, it merely shifts activity without addressing underlying behaviours, its effectiveness will remain limited.

In the final analysis, taxes like STT are blunt instruments in a nuanced ecosystem. They can influence behaviour, but they cannot fully shape it. As India's capital markets continue to deepen and democratise, the challenge for policymakers will be to strike the right balance—between regulation and freedom, between deterrence and participation, and ultimately, between short-term activity and long-term wealth creation.

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A VETERAN JOURNALIST AND COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

Social media companies have been pulled up and held accountable for sparking obsession and harming the youth. For India, home to the world's largest child and youth population, the deep-seated warning couldn't be clearer

STATECRAFT



KRITI MEHTA

THE WRITER IS A SENIOR JOURNALIST WITH DIVERSE EXPERIENCE ACROSS LEADING NATIONAL NEWS ORGANISATIONS

The story of Palaniswami is less about projection and more about process—where governance is shaped through continuity, detail and a sustained connection with the ground

Algorithmic Addiction

A US court judgment against social media giants raises burning questions on addictive platform design and the risks to 'digital children', including in India

"The problem facing humanity is that we have Palaeolithic emotions, medieval institutions and God-like technology." — E.O. Wilson

A courtroom verdict delivered half-way around the world in California may end up forcing India to confront a scratchy question in this digital age: Are social media platforms designed in a way that can harm the very users they claim to connect? In a closely-watched case in the US, a jury ruled that platforms operated by Meta and services owned by Google contributed to mental harm suffered by a young user, who argued that exposure to their platforms deepened her depression and fostered addictive behavioural patterns.

The lawsuit centred on widely-used services Instagram and YouTube. The plaintiff claimed the platforms were not merely neutral tools for communication, but "deliberately engineered environments designed to maximise engagement, especially among younger users". After hearing expert testimony and reviewing evidence, jurors concluded that the companies had been negligent. They awarded damages as well.

Experts believe this scathing verdict could lead to a turning point in how the tech industry is scrutinised. For decades, digital platforms have relied on legal protections that shield them from responsibility for content posted by users. This particular case bypassed that defence entirely, focusing on product design alone. The moot question before the court was not what users posted, but how the platforms themselves were built. If digital platforms begin to be examined like other consumer products—as one whose design may create risk for the user—the implications will extend far beyond a single lawsuit in the United States.

For India, the debate could not be more relevant.

**Keen Model of Attention**

For years, psychologists and tech critics have argued that modern social media platforms are engineered around one overriding objective: to capture and hold human attention. Every single notification, every algorithmically-curated reel, every endless scroll is designed to keep users engaged for as long as possible. The longer users stay on a platform, the more advertisements they see. And the more revenue the platform generates. This is the essence of what economists call the 'Attention Economy'. The mechanism works through a feedback loop. Platforms analyse what users watch, pause on, like or comment on, and quickly supply more of the same. 'Autoplay' removes natural stopping points. Infinite feeds ensure there is always another video, another image or another conversation waiting in the protocol stack.

For adults, this may result in distraction or habitual phone-checking.



Few countries illustrate the scale of the digital takeover more vividly than India

For adolescents, the psychological pull can be stronger. Teenagers are particularly sensitive to social validation. Social media converts validation into hard numbers, such as likes, shares, comments and follower counts. Identity formation, historically shaped largely by family, school and neighbourhood, is now being scrutinized by digital audiences.

Researchers are increasingly linking social media use with sleep disruption, anxiety and depression among young people. In India, studies show smartphone addiction is affecting 39-44 per cent of users, a number that highlights the numbing scale of the problem. The lawsuit in the US did not argue that harmful online content exists. It argued that the very architecture of social media platforms encourages compulsive behaviour. That claim is now echoing beyond Silicon Valley, with its reverberations being felt in India.

**India's Digital Boom**

Few countries illustrate the scale of the digital takeover more vividly than India. The country has seen the fastest expansion of connectivity anywhere in the world. Affordable smartphones, cheap data prices and expanding digital infrastructure have brought crores online. Platforms like Instagram, YouTube, WhatsApp and Facebook are now part of everyday life. Students team up through messaging groups, influencers build careers through quick-see videos and businesses reach customers through social media marketing. For young Indians, the Internet is not a tool; it is the central arena of social interaction and aspiration.

Yet, the speed of this transformation has produced anxieties, perhaps because India has the largest adolescent population in the world. Studies on digital behaviour show that young Indians and teenagers spend four to five hours a day glued to their screens. Teachers are reporting shrinking attention spans in classrooms. Parents are struggling to regulate screen-time with smartphones becoming ubiquitous. India's classrooms are reporting declining concentration

and anxiety among students due to screen addiction.

Mental health experts are seeing similar patterns. Doctors in Coimbatore and Bengaluru are tracking cases where teenagers show symptoms of behavioural addiction to phones—anxiety, sleep disruption and compulsive checking of social feeds. The trend is not limited to the elite. As cheaper smartphones reach small towns and rural regions, patterns of social media abuse are being reported across socioeconomic boundaries. Clearly, the digital revolution has moved faster than the society's ability to adapt.

**Debate is Yet to Begin**

Disturbingly, India's regulatory conversation on this issue has been focused on issues like misinformation, online abuse, national security and data protection. Government policies have cracked down on content moderation and accountability for unlawful posts, these being legitimate concerns in a vast and diverse nation. But the US verdict raises a deeper question: whether the design of digital platforms is itself creating psychological risks, particularly among children and teenagers. If courts begin examining algorithms, recommendation engines and engagement features, India will become part of the dialogue. After all, it represents one of the largest user bases for the very platforms that are now under scrutiny. Digital policy experts are asking whether safeguards like algorithmic transparency, stronger protection for minors and limits on addictive features should be brought under regulatory scrutiny. The question is not whether social media should exist; it is whether the digital ecosystem should operate without meaningful guardrails.

The debate is not merely technological; it is profoundly social too. A generation of young Indians is growing up in a world where identity, popularity and self-worth are being measured through digital metrics. The pressure to curate an idealised online persona is hideously intensifying social comparison and anxiety. Influencer culture,

viral trends and algorithmic recommendations are amplifying unrealistic standards of beauty, success and lifestyle. For teenagers navigating complex emotional transitions, this is creating an environment of constant comparison. Psychologists warn that such dynamics may end up altering how young people perceive themselves and their relationships with others.

Sleep disruption is another growing concern. Studies examining adolescents in India have found a clear association between heavy smartphone use and sleep problems, an issue that directly affects academic performance and emotional well-being. At the same time, the digital environment is not entirely negative. Social media has also enabled younger Indians to discover communities, access information and express creativity in ways that were unimaginable only a decade ago.

The challenge, therefore, lies in ensuring that the benefits do not come at the cost of psychological health.

**Time for Digital Reset?**

History offers a useful perspective. Transformative technologies often pass through a phase of exuberant adoption before society begins throwing in safety standards. Automobiles eventually required seatbelts and airbags. Medicines underwent tough clinical testing. Aviation developed strict engineering protocols. Technology may now be approaching a similar moment.

Thus, for the sake of India's children and youth, the response must be thoughtful, not reactionary or knee-jerk. Schools need to equip students with digital literacy that explains how algorithms shape behaviour. Parents need to be made aware of the psychological mechanics embedded within social media platforms. Policymakers must explore frameworks that encourage safer design; through transparency requirements, stronger protections for minors and limits on features that encourage compulsive use. Technology firms themselves face a pivotal choice. They can continue defending engagement-driven platforms built around ad revenues, or they can lead a redesign that places user well-being at the centre of digital innovation.

India faces a tough question. And the California verdict will face appeals, with legal proceedings stretching and agonizing for years. But the broader message has already travelled beyond the Los Angeles courthouse. For the first time, a jury has declared that the architecture of social media itself can cause harm. In India, where crores of young people are growing up inside the digital ecosystem, the poser is no longer whether the problem exists. It is whether we will confront it now. Before an entire generation learns that the platforms shaping their lives were never designed for their well-being, but for their attention.

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Governance Beyond Political Spectacle

As Tamil Nadu approaches elections, Palaniswami's governance reflects a blend of welfare, infrastructure and grassroots engagement rather than high-decibel political messaging



Palaniswami's administrative style offers a counterpoint to spectacle politics, prioritising delivery, infrastructure and responsiveness

observing how policy translates into everyday impact.

When he became Chief Minister in 2017, it was not about celebrations or power; it was under circumstances that would have tested any leader. The passing of J. Jayalalithaa had left both the government and the party in a fragile state, raising questions about continuity and control. His leadership during this period was marked by a certain administrative restraint. He focused on bringing stability to the state and the party.

Despite the trying times, a defining characteristic of his administrative tenure was his unwavering commitment to infrastructure development. The construction of highways, rural roadways, irrigation networks, and

water management systems exemplified this focus, supporting the economic growth of the region. These are investments that rarely produce immediate political dividends, but they shape the conditions for growth in more lasting ways.

At the same time, his administrative style retained a strong element of accessibility. Palaniswami worked to reduce the distance between the government and citizens. The grievance redressal mechanism instituted during his tenure reflected an attempt to make the state more responsive in practice, not just in principle. Frequent district visits and review meetings reinforced this, ensuring that governance remained anchored in feedback from the ground.

Perhaps the clearest illustration of his approach came during the COVID-19 pandemic. In Tamil Nadu's case, the response under Palaniswami combined scale with balance. Testing capacity was ramped up rapidly, welfare support reached around Rs 40,000 crore, and there was a conscious effort to keep industrial activity moving where possible. He attempted to manage both public health and economic continuity without allowing one to completely overwhelm the other.

With Tamil Nadu heading for elections, the party's current approach, which combines welfare measures like income support and cost-of-living relief with a broader push for infrastructure-led growth, reflects an attempt to balance immediate needs with long-term capacity building.

In many ways, Palaniswami's politics resists easy categorisation. It is not built on high-decibel messaging or singular moments of projection. Instead, it is defined by accumulation—of organisational experience, administrative familiarity, and a consistent engagement with the mechanics of governance.

Which brings the story back to that brief roadside exchange. In a state where politics often plays out on large stages, it is in such smaller, unscripted moments that a different kind of leadership becomes visible—one that measures itself not just by what is promised, but by what can be explained, implemented, and ultimately delivered.

Views expressed are personal



OVER 1,100 PEOPLE HAVE BEEN KILLED SO FAR

# ‘Israel will widen its invasion of Lebanon’



The crisis sparked fertilizer shortages and disrupted air travel

**ISLAMABAD:** Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu announced Sunday that Israel will widen its invasion of southern Lebanon.

Netanyahu said Israel would expand what he called the “existing security strip” in Lebanon as Israeli forces continue to target the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group. “We are determined to fundamentally change the situation in the north,” he said on a visit to northern Israel, adding that “Hezbollah still has residual capability to fire rockets at us.” There were no immediate details.

In Lebanon, officials say more than 1,100 people have been killed in the fighting since the Iran war began.

Meanwhile, Iranian-backed Houthi rebels entered the month-old war in the Middle East on Saturday, claiming two missile launches at Israel.

About 2,500 US Marines

## Highlights

- » About 2,500 US Marines arrived in the region
- » The war has threatened global supplies of oil and natural gas

## THE US AND ISRAEL CONTINUE TO STRIKE IRAN

arrived in the region. And Pakistan’s government said that regional powers plan to meet Sunday to discuss how to end the fighting. The war has threatened global supplies of oil and natural gas, sparked fertilizer shortages and disrupted air travel. Iran’s grip on the strategic Strait of Hormuz has shaken markets and prices.

The United States and Israel continue to strike Iran, whose retaliatory attacks have

targeted Israel and neighboring Gulf Arab states. More than 3,000 people have been killed.

The Houthis’ entry could further hurt global shipping if they again target vessels in the Bab el-Mandeb Strait off the Red Sea, through which about 12 per cent of the world’s trade typically passes. There could be limited relief after Iran on Friday agreed to allow humanitarian aid and agricultural shipments through the Strait of Hormuz following a United Nations request. US President Donald Trump, meanwhile, has given Iran until April 6 to reopen the strait.

Witnesses in Tehran reported heavy strikes late Saturday. Israel’s military earlier said that it targeted Iran’s naval weapons production facilities, and said that it would finish attacking essential weapons production sites within “a few days.”

AGENCIES

## Saudi, Egypt, Turkiye FM’s in Pak to discuss West Asia crisis

**ISLAMABAD:** Foreign Ministers of Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Turkiye and Pakistan held consultations on the West Asia conflict in Islamabad on Sunday to find a way to de-escalate the ongoing war that has unsettled the region and caused severe global economic disruptions. The foreign ministers discussed the evolving regional situation and exchanged views on security issues while exploring options for broader peace in the region, an official said.

The talks were held amidst a delay in the direct talks between the US and Iran. No statement was issued after the meeting. Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty and Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan arrived in Islamabad on Saturday, while their Saudi counterpart, Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, reached here on Sunday at the invitation of Pakistan Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar.

The two-day quadrilateral summit is Pakistan’s attempt to broker peace in West Asia. After the meeting, the Saudi

“THE TALKS WERE HELD AMIDST A DELAY IN THE DIRECT TALKS BETWEEN THE US AND IRAN. NO STATEMENT WAS ISSUED AFTER THE MEETING”

Foreign Minister Prince Faisal bin Farhan called on Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and discussed various matters of bilateral and regional interest.

Earlier, Dar held a meeting with the Saudi Foreign Minister on the sidelines of the quadrilateral huddle, the Foreign Office (FO) said. “During the meeting, the two leaders held detailed discussions on the evolving regional and international developments. They underscored the importance of dialogue, diplomacy, and collective efforts to promote peace, security and stability in the region,” it said.

“Reaffirming their commitment for closer engagement, the two sides agreed to continue working together at bilateral and multilateral levels to further strengthen cooperation and contribute to regional peace and prosperity,” it added.

Dar also held bilateral talks with his counterparts from Egypt and Turkiye on Sunday on the sidelines of the summit.

The FO said Pakistan and Egypt expressed satisfaction with the positive momentum generated through recent high-level exchanges, including the visit of Abdelatty to Pakistan in November last year.

In a press statement on Saturday, the FO said the visiting foreign ministers will hold “in-depth discussions on a range of issues, including efforts to de-escalate tensions in the region”. Separately, the FO in a midnight post on X said that Dar held a telephonic conversation with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and “discussed the evolving regional situation and ongoing developments”. AGENCIES

## Ex-PM Oli remanded in judicial custody for 5 days

Protests continue across Nepal

**KATHMANDU:** Nepal’s former Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli was remanded in judicial custody for five days by the Kathmandu District Court on Sunday, even as protests continue to erupt in various parts of the country over the arrests.

Oli and former home minister Ramesh Lekhak were arrested on Saturday for their alleged involvement in suppressing the Gen Z movement of September 8 and 9 last year, in which 76 people, including around two dozen youths, were killed.

The arrests came a day after the newly formed Balendra Shah government decided to implement the report of the probe commission into the Gen Z protests in its first cabinet meeting.

Lekhak was presented before the district court seeking remand for ten days to carry out further investigation into their alleged involvement in the incidents of killings. He was also remanded in custody



Former Nepal PM K P Oli

The arrests came a day after the newly formed govt decided to implement the report of the probe commission into the Gen Z protests

for five days.

However, ex-PM Oli virtually attended the district court session due to his deteriorating health conditions, according to Deepak Kumar Shrestha, information officer at the district court.

AGENCIES

## SOME WARN OF TRUMP-LIKE TACTICS

# Europe seeks to increase deportations

**BRUSSELS:** The European Union is expanding its powers to track, raid and deport migrants to “return hubs” in third countries in Africa and elsewhere, quietly adopting tactics of the Trump administration that have drawn public criticism across the 27-nation bloc. The EU continues to tighten migration policies after right-wing parties took power in some countries in 2024. European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, from the centre-right European People’s Party coalition, has said the new measures will prevent a repeat of the 2015

The EU continues to tighten migration policies after right-wing parties took power in some countries in 2024

crisis caused by the civil war in Syria, when about one million people arrived to seek asylum.

“We have learnt the lessons of the past. And today, we are better equipped,” von der Leyen has said. The new policies, known as the Pact

on Migration and Asylum, go into effect on June 12. Far-right parties in Europe have praised the deportation policies of US President Donald Trump and called for the EU to adopt a similar approach. Human rights groups warn that authorities are already illegally pushing back migrants at EU borders and hollowing out their legal protections.

The EU already spends millions of dollars to deter migrants before they reach its shores, and has supported tens of thousands of Africans returning home, voluntarily or by force. What’s envisioned

now is an expansion of what Italy has created under Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni and her “tough on migration” stance. It operates two migrant detention centre for rejected asylum-seekers in Albania. One currently holds at least 90 migrants, said lawmaker Rachele Scarpa, who said she found people confused and scared during a recent visit.

In addition, Meloni’s Cabinet has approved an anti-immigration package that would allow the navy to halt vessels in international waters for up to six months if they are deemed a threat to public order. AGENCIES

## ‘No Kings’ rallies draw crowds across United States

**ST PAUL:** Large crowds protested Saturday against the war in Iran and President Donald Trump’s actions in “No Kings” rallies across the US and in Europe.

Minnesota took center stage, with thousands of people standing shoulder-to-shoulder to celebrate resistance to Trump’s aggressive immigration enforcement.

Minnesota’s flagship event on the Capitol lawn in St. Paul drew Bruce Springsteen as its headliner. He and other speakers praised the state’s people for taking to the streets over the winter in opposition to a surge of U.S. Customs and Immigration Enforcement agents.

Springsteen performed “Streets of Minneapolis,” the song he wrote in response to the fatal shootings of Renee Good and Alex Pretti by federal agents. Springsteen lamented Good and Pretti’s deaths but said the state’s pushback against ICE has given the rest of the country hope.

“Your strength and your commitment told us that this was still America,” he said. “And this reactionary nightmare, and these invasions of American cities, will not stand.” People rallied from New York City, with almost 8.5 million residents in a solidly blue state, to Driggs, a town of fewer than 2,000 people in eastern Idaho, a state Trump carried with 66 per cent of the vote in 2024. AGENCIES

## Extreme weather in Afghanistan leaves 17 dead

**KABUL:** Severe flooding, a landslide and thunderstorms in parts of Afghanistan left 17 people dead and 26 injured over the last 24 hours, with more heavy rainfall predicted, authorities said Sunday.

The number of casualties could increase as crews from the country’s National Disaster Management Authority survey the affected areas, the authority’s spokesman, Yousuf Hammad, said in a statement.

Thirteen of Afghanistan’s 34 provinces, mostly in the western, central and northwestern parts of the country, were affected.

The severe weather also left 147 homes either completely or partially destroyed, wiped out 80 km of roads and destroyed agricultural land and irrigation canals and businesses, Hammad said. In all, he said, 530 families were affected.

AGENCIES

## North Korea conducts engine test for missile capable of targeting US mainland

**SEOUL:** North Korean leader Kim Jong Un observed a test of a high-thrust, solid-fuel engine test and hailed it as a development to boost the country’s strategic military capability, state media reported Sunday.

The test likely indicates Kim is intent on enlarging and modernising an arsenal of missiles capable of reaching the United States mainland.

The report on Sunday from Korean Central News Agency (KCNA) came days after Kim delivered a speech at North Korea’s Parliament pledging to irreversibly cement his country’s status as a nuclear power and accusing the US of global “state terrorism and aggression,” in an apparent reference to the war in the Middle East.

Kim watched the ground jet test of the newly upgraded engine using a composite carbon fibre material, according to the KCNA, which reported the engine’s maximum thrust is 2,500 kilotons, up from about



North Korean leader Kim Jong Un

1,971 kilotons reported in a similar solid fuel engine test in September. A push to increase the engine power is likely associated with efforts to place multiple warheads on a single missile to increase chances of defeating US defences, observers say.

The KCNA did not report exactly when or where the test occurred. The test was conducted as part of the country’s five-year military escalation program. The plan’s objectives include upgrading “stra-

The test likely indicates Kim is intent on enlarging and modernising an arsenal of missiles capable of reaching the United States mainland

tegic strike means,” the KCNA reported. The reference is understood to mean nuclear-capable, intercontinental ballistic missiles targeting the continental US.

Kim said the latest engine test had “great significance in putting the country’s strategic military muscle on the high level,” the KCNA reported.

In recent years, North Korea has test-fired a variety of ICBMs demonstrating the potential range to reach the US mainland, including mis-

siles with solid propellants that make detection prior to liftoff more difficult.

The country’s older liquid-fuel missiles must be fuelled before liftoffs and cannot last long. Some foreign experts say North Korea still faces technological hurdles before it has a functioning ICBM, such as ensuring its warheads survive the harsh conditions of atmospheric reentry.

But others dispute that assessment given the number of years the country has spent on its nuclear and missile programs. North Korea has pushed hard to expand its nuclear arsenal since Kim’s high-stakes diplomacy with US.

President Donald Trump collapsed in 2019. In a ruling Workers’ Party congress in February, Kim left open the door for dialogue with Trump but urged Washington to drop demands for the North’s nuclear disarmament as a precondition for talks. AGENCIES

## ‘Russia concerned with possibility of US taking control of Afghan airbase’

**MOSCOW:** Moscow is apprehensive that the US could try to take control of a key Afghan Base amid its escalating military conflict with Iran, a senior Russian diplomat has said.

Speaking in an interview with the government news agency RIA Novosti on Saturday, Russian President Vladimir Putin’s special envoy on Afghanistan, Zamir Kabulov, said that the US demand for the Bagram airbase is not new.

The Bagram airbase, located near the capital city, Kabul, was built in the 1950s by the erstwhile Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) and was widely used by the Soviet forces during their intervention in Afghanistan, and later by the US and NATO forces in operations against the Afghan Taliban.

“The Trump administration constantly voices demands for the return of the Bagram air-

base in Afghanistan, which the US lost after their inglorious retreat from Afghanistan in August 2021,” Kabulov said.

His response came after he was asked to comment on the possibility of the US renewing its demand to the Afghan regime to access the Bagram airbase in the backdrop of massive US military deployment in West Asia.

Russia does not accept the deployment of US and NATO military facilities and infrastructure in Afghanistan or neighbouring states, he said.

“We hope the authorities of the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan will continue to adhere to a similar approach,” he added.

In September 2025, US President Donald Trump had expressed a desire to regain control of Bagram airbase, a facility abandoned during the 2021 withdrawal, citing its strategic proximity to China. AGENCIES

## Speech by Imran Khan’s son being ‘misrepresented’ to mislead public: KPK CM

**PESHAWAR:** Pakistan’s Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Sohail Afridi on Sunday alleged that a recent speech by Kasim Khan, son of former prime minister Imran Khan, was being “deliberately misrepresented” by the government in an attempt to mislead the public.

Addressing a press conference, Afridi said that authorities were trying to shift blame for their economic failures onto Kasim to conceal their own incompetence.

“We have translated Kasim Khan’s speech into Urdu to present the facts before the nation,” Afridi stated.

He alleged that the speech was being “deliberately misrepresented” by the government in an attempt to mislead the public.

Highlighting international standards, the chief minister said that European countries require adherence to democracy, human rights, environmental protection, and

Sohail Afridi said that authorities were trying to shift blame for their economic failures onto Kasim to conceal their own incompetence

transparent governance for trade relations.

He alleged that the current federal government was violating these principles while attempting to blame the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI).

Afridi reiterated that Pakistan should qualify for the GSP Plus trade status and stressed the importance of meeting international benchmarks.

He further accused the ruling leadership of being “blinded by political hostility” towards 73-year-old Khan, claiming that the public no longer wishes to see them in power.

AGENCIES

## US-ISRAELI WAR ON IRAN ENTERS ITS 2<sup>ND</sup> MONTH

# Pope Leo rejects claims that God justifies war in Palm Sunday Mass message

**ROME:** Pope Leo XIV on Sunday rejected claims that God justifies war and prayed especially for Christians in the Middle East during a Palm Sunday Mass before tens of thousands of people in St. Peter’s Square.

With the US-Israeli war on Iran entering its second month and Russia’s ongoing campaign in Ukraine, Leo dedicated his Palm Sunday homily to insisting that God is the “king of peace” who rejects violence and comforts those who are oppressed.

“Brothers and sisters, this is our God: Jesus, King of Peace, who rejects war, whom no one can use to justify war,” Leo said. “He does not listen to the prayers of those who wage war, but rejects them.”

Leaders on all sides of the Iran war have used religion to justify their actions. US officials, especially Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth, have invoked their Christian faith to cast the war



Pope Leo XIV presides over Palm Sunday Mass in St. Peter’s Square at the Vatican on Sunday

## Key Points

» Leaders on all sides of the ongoing Iran war have used religion to justify

## their actions

» Palm Sunday marks Jesus’ triumphant entrance into Jerusalem in the time leading up to his crucifixion

as a Christian nation trying to vanquish its foes with military might.

Russia’s Orthodox Church, too, has justified Russia’s invasion of Ukraine as a “holy war”

against a Western world it considers has fallen into evil.

Palm Sunday marks Jesus’ triumphant entrance into Jerusalem in the time leading up to his crucifixion, which Christians observe on Good Friday, and resurrection on Easter Sunday.

In a special blessing at the end of Mass, Leo said he was praying especially for Christians in the Middle East who are “suffering the consequences of an atrocious conflict. In many cases, they cannot live the rites of these holy days.”

Earlier Sunday, the Latin Patriarchate said Jerusalem police prevented the Catholic church’s top leadership from entering the Church of the Holy Sepulchre.

It was the first time in centuries that church leaders were prevented from celebrating Palm Sunday at the place where Christians believe Jesus was crucified, the Patriarchate said. AGENCIES

## World Briefs

### EGYPTIAN DIPLOMAT NABIL FAHMY APPOINTED AS NEW ARAB LEAGUE CHIEF

**CAIRO:** Arab foreign ministers on Sunday appointed veteran Egyptian diplomat Nabil Fahmy as the head of the 22-member Arab League, at a time the Middle East is plunged into a monthlong Iran war that shows no sign of abating. Fahmy, a former Egyptian foreign minister, won the support of the Arab foreign ministers in a virtual meeting, according to the Egyptian Foreign Ministry. Fahmy’s five-year term will start in July, succeeding Ahmed Aboul Gheit, who has served as Arab League chief since 2016. His appointment came as Iran’s Arab neighbours are reeling from attacks by Iran and its proxies in response to massive airstrikes launched by the US and Israel since Feb. 28.

### MISSING SAILBOATS CARRYING AID ARRIVE IN CUBA

**HAVANA:** Two sailboats that went missing carrying humanitarian aid from southern Mexico to Cuba landed in Havana on Saturday afternoon hours after they went incommunicado because of bad weather. The vessels carrying at least eight people departed from Isla Mujeres in southern Mexico on March 20 and then lost contact, fuelling concern in Mexico, Cuba and beyond.



# Airlines to offer 60% seats in flights without extra charges from April 20

In this regard, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) issued the amended Air Transport Circular dated March 20

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Airlines will start offering at least 60 per cent of seats in a flight without levying any additional charge from April 20, as well as maintain a transparent seat allocation policy, according to aviation watchdog DGCA.

On March 18, the civil aviation ministry announced that directions have been issued to the DGCA to direct airlines to allocate a minimum of 60 per cent of seats for selection on any flight free of charge to ensure fair access for passengers.

In this regard, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) issued the amended Air Transport Circular dated March 20. A DGCA official said the circular would come into effect from April 20.

The regulator has said that airlines should ensure at least “60 per cent of the seats in any flight shall be offered free of charge”.

“Airlines should maintain transparent seat allocation poli-



‘Airlines should maintain transparent seat allocation policies and clearly communicate the availability of free seats and applicable conditions on their booking interfaces,’ as per the revised circular

cies and clearly communicate the availability of free seats and applicable conditions on their booking interfaces,” as per a revised circular dated March 20.

Also, the regulator has said that passengers travelling on the same PNR (Passenger Name Record) should, as far as prac-

ticable, be allotted seats in close proximity to one another, ordinarily meaning adjacent seats in the same row.

An official said airlines are preparing to implement the new directive. At present, 20 per cent of the seats can be booked free of charge, while the rest are paid.

Highlights

- » The DGCA has said that airlines should ensure at least ‘60% of the seats in any flight shall be offered free of charge’
- » At present, 20 per cent of the seats can be booked free of charge, while the rest are paid
- » Generally, airlines charge Rs 200 to Rs 2,100 for choosing seats, depending on various factors, including front rows and extra leg room, a travel industry executive had said

services relating to sports equipment or musical instruments, including any liability conditions in case of damage, should be displayed in a transparent and unambiguous manner on airline websites and booking platforms. DGCA has said the circular will take effect 30 days from its issuance date.

The move also comes against the backdrop of rising concerns that airlines are levying high charges for various services, including seat selection.

Last week, IndiGo, Air India and SpiceJet raised strong objections to the decision, asking airlines not to levy any charges for the selection of at least 60 per cent seats on flights, saying the move will force them to hike airfares to recover lost revenues.

In a letter to the civil aviation ministry on March 20, the Federation of Indian Airlines (FIA), which represents the three airlines, had urged the ministry to take steps to withdraw the decision. Indian airports handle over five lakh passengers daily.

# FPIs dump record ₹1.14 lakh cr in March on West Asia conflict

With one trading session still remaining in the month, the outflows could extend further

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Foreign investors have pulled out Rs 1.14 lakh crore (about \$12.3 billion) from domestic equities in March, making it the worst monthly outflow, weighed down by escalating tensions in West Asia, a weakening rupee and concerns over the impact of elevated crude oil prices on India's growth.

With one trading session still remaining in the month, the outflows could extend further.

The previous record for the highest monthly exodus stood at Rs 94,017 crore in October 2024.

With the latest withdrawals, total foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) outflow has reached Rs 1.27 lakh crore so far in 2026, according to NSDL data.

As per the data, FPIs have remained persistent sellers throughout March, offloading equities worth Rs 1,13,380 crore in the cash market till March 27.

The sharp sell-off follows a strong rebound in February, when foreign FPIs pumped in Rs 22,615 crore, the highest



With the latest withdrawals, total foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) outflow has reached Rs 1.27 lakh crore so far in 2026, according to NSDL data

monthly inflow in 17 months.

Market participants attributed the sustained selling pressure to global macroeconomic headwinds and heightened geopolitical uncertainty.

VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, said the weakness in global equity markets following the war in West

Asia, the steady depreciation of the rupee, fears of decline in remittances from the Gulf region and concerns surrounding the impact of high crude prices on India's growth and corporate earnings contributed to the sustained selling by foreign portfolio investors.

Additionally, the selling has been driven by a combination of elevated US bond yields and tightening global liquidity, which have improved the relative attractiveness of developed market fixed income, Himanshu Srivastava, Principal - Manager Research at Morningstar Investment Research India, said.

While Indian market valuations have corrected alongside the recent market decline, they continue to remain relatively elevated compared to several emerging market peers, which may still be prompting selective profit booking and reallocation, he added.

Moreover, FPIs were sellers in other emerging markets, too, like Taiwan and South Korea. There is a risk-off trend in equity markets globally after the war broke out in West Asia.

# Mcap of 7 of top-10 cos drops by ₹1.75 lakh cr



NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of seven of the top-10 most valued firms tumbled by Rs 1.75 lakh crore in a holiday-shortened last week, with Reliance Industries taking the biggest hit, in tandem with a weak trend in equities.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex lost 949.74 points or 1.27 per cent, and the NSE Nifty tanked 294.9 points or 1.27 per cent.

“Markets ended the week on a weaker note, reflecting heightened volatility amid fluctuating global cues and escalating geopolitical tensions in the Middle East. The week was marked by sharp swings, with early losses driven by concerns over energy supply disruptions, a weakening rupee, which touched a record low, and rising volatility,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

This was followed by a mid-week recovery on hopes of a temporary de-escalation in US-Iran tensions, he noted.

“However, renewed selling pressure on Friday erased the gains, dragging indices lower,” Mishra added.

The market valuation of Reliance Industries eroded by Rs 89,720.3 crore to Rs 18,24,515.62 crore.

HDFC Bank's valuation tanked by Rs 37,248.59 crore to Rs 11,64,018.69 crore.

State Bank of India lost Rs 35,399.42 crore from its market valuation, which stood at Rs 9,41,569.15 crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of ICICI Bank dropped by Rs 8,121.76 crore to Rs 8,83,551.30 crore, and that of Bharti Airtel declined by Rs 2,480.42 crore to Rs 10,50,413.33 crore.

Hindustan Unilever's mcap diminished by Rs 2,091.13 crore to Rs 4,87,540.19 crore, and that of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) dipped by Rs 271.35 crore to Rs 8,64,668.65 crore.

However, the market valuation of Larsen & Toubro surged by Rs 18,051.68 crore to Rs 4,90,536.19 crore.

The mcap of Bajaj Finance jumped Rs 8,680.36 crore to Rs 5,25,395.48 crore.

Infosys added Rs 6,245.3 crore, taking its valuation to Rs 5,15,034.67 crore.

Reliance Industries retained the title of the most valued firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, State Bank of India, ICICI Bank, Tata Consultancy Services, Bajaj Finance, Infosys, Larsen & Toubro and Hindustan Unilever.

# NSE to launch Dated Brent Crude Oil futures from April 13

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) will introduce Dated Brent Crude Oil (Platts) futures from April 13, expanding its commodity derivatives offerings linked to global oil benchmarks.

The contract, based on the S&P Global Energy (Platts) Dated Brent assessment, will be traded under the symbol “BRCRUDEOIL”.

“The exchange is pleased to inform its members that, having received approval from Sebi, Dated Brent Crude Oil (Platts) Futures contracts would be available for trading in the NSE commodity derivatives segment with effect from April 13, 2026,” the bourse said in its circular.

The introduction of the contract aims to provide market participants with a hedging tool aligned with international crude benchmarks.

The futures contracts will be listed on a monthly basis, with trading scheduled from Monday to Friday between 9:00 am and 11:30 pm/11:55 pm, depending on US daylight saving time.

The contracts will be cash-settled, with the final settlement price determined based on the monthly simple average of Platts Dated Brent assessments, converted into rupees using the RBI's USD-INR reference rate. The exchange said the contracts will follow quality specifications as prescribed by S&P Global Energy (Platts).

## ATTENTION! GST TAXPAYERS

Whose Aggregate Annual Turnover<sup>#</sup> is upto a specified limit\* can opt for GST Composition Scheme for the FY 2026–2027 by 31st March, 2026

Eligible taxpayers who wish to avail the Composition Scheme can follow these steps on the GST portal ([www.gst.gov.in](http://www.gst.gov.in)):

- Log in to the Taxpayers' Interface
- Go to Services >Registration > Application to Opt for Composition Levy
- Fill the FORM GST CMP-02 and submit

Those eligible taxpayers, who are already availing Composition Scheme, need not file FORM CMP-02 if they are eligible.

- Easy & Convenient Compliance
- Attractive Tax Rates
- Minimum Compliance Requirements
- Automatic Continuation/Renewal to next year and Easy to Opt-out
- Available for supplier of Goods as well as Services
- Less Bookkeeping

| * Type of Suppliers  |                                             | # Aggregate Annual Turnover during FY 2025-26 |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Supplier of Goods    | Taxpayers registered in 08 Specified States | upto ₹75 Lakh                                 |
|                      | Taxpayers registered in other States        | upto ₹150 Lakh                                |
| Supplier of Services |                                             | upto ₹50 Lakh                                 |

For more details, please refer to section 10 of CGST Act, Rule 3-7 of CGST Rules and Notification No. 14/2019 - Central Tax dated 07.03.2019

### GST Composition Scheme: Big Benefits for Small Taxpayers

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# West Asia conflict, crude oil prices to drive markets next week: Analysts

Besides, the rupee-dollar trend & trading activity of foreign investors would also play a crucial role

NEW DELHI: Developments related to the ongoing month-long war in West Asia, its impact on crude oil prices, and global trends would continue to be key drivers for domestic equities in the holiday-shortened week ahead, analysts said.

Besides, the rupee-dollar trend and trading activity of foreign investors would also play a crucial role in dictating investors' sentiment.

Stock markets would remain closed on Tuesday and Friday for Shri Mahavir Jayanti and Good Friday, respectively.

“This week is expected to remain influenced by global macro developments, particularly crude oil price trends and

progress in the US-Iran ceasefire negotiations, which will be critical in shaping market sentiment. Stability in the rupee will also be important for any revival in foreign institutional flows,” Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

On the domestic front, key data releases include industrial production data for February and the HSBC Manufacturing PMI for March, which will provide insights into economic momentum and fiscal positioning, he said.

Foreign investors have pulled out Rs 1.14 lakh crore (about \$12.3 billion) from domestic equities this month amid the widening conflict in

West Asia and a weakening rupee.

The West Asia conflict started on February 28. While the US and Israel attacked Iran, the Islamic Republic retaliated by targeting Washington's allies in its neighbourhood and Tel Aviv.

Foreign investor flows, moves in the rupee, and broader global market trends are also likely to play a key role in shaping the near-term outlook, he said.

In a holiday-shortened last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex lost 949.74 points or 1.27 per cent, and the NSE Nifty tanked 294.9 points or 1.27 per cent.



# Govt ramps up measures to ensure fuel, LPG supplies amid disruption

‘Two LPG carriers, BW TYR & BW ELM, carrying 94K tonnes LPG, have safely transited the region & are moving towards Indian shores’

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The government has stepped up measures to secure fuel and gas supplies amid the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, while urging citizens to avoid panic buying as sporadic ruses were reported at fuel stations.

In a statement, giving an update on developments following the war in West Asia, the oil ministry said refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories, and stocks of petrol and diesel remain sufficient nationwide. Retail outlets are functioning normally, even as rumours triggered temporary spikes in demand in some states.

“There were certain rumours, which led to panic buying at some retail outlets in a few states, resulting in unusually high sales and heavy crowding at retail outlets. However, it is informed that there are adequate stocks of petrol and diesel available at all petrol pumps in the country,” it said.

To boost domestic availability, the government has cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by Rs 10 per litre and imposed export levies of Rs 21.50 per litre on diesel and Rs 29.50 per litre on aviation turbine fuel (ATF).



The govt has cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by Rs 10 per litre and imposed export levies of Rs 21.50 per litre on diesel and Rs 29.50 per litre on ATF

In the gas sector, supplies have been prioritised for households and transport, with 100 per cent allocation to piped natural gas (PNG) and CNG, while industrial and commercial users are receiving about 80 per cent of average consumption. Fertiliser plants are being supplied at 70-75 per cent, with additional LNG cargoes being sourced, it said.

The ministry said the expansion of city gas distribution networks is being accelerated by streamlining approvals and pushing a shift from LPG to piped natural gas (PNG).

More than 2,90,000 new

(PNG) gas connections were added in March, while companies, including Indraprastha Gas, Mahanagar Gas, GAIL Gas and BPCL, are offering incentives for PNG adoption.

LPG supplies have been impacted by the geopolitical situation, though deliveries remain normal with no reported shortages. Daily refill deliveries exceeded 55 lakh cylinders, and measures to curb diversion have been tightened, it said. Commercial LPG supply has been gradually restored to about 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels, with priority given to hospitality, food services and

## Highlights

- » Gas supplies have been prioritised for households & transport with 100% allocation to PNG and CNG
- » Industrial & commercial users are receiving about 80 per cent of average consumption
- » Fertiliser plants are being supplied at 70-75 per cent, with additional LNG cargoes being sourced

key industries.

The government has also increased kerosene allocations to states and intensified enforcement against hoarding and black marketing, conducting about 2,900 raids and seizing around 1,000 cylinders recently. States have been directed to step up monitoring, conduct daily briefings, counter misinformation and fast-track gas infrastructure approvals.

“The government reiterates its advice to the public not to believe rumours,” the statement said.

“Government is making all efforts to ensure the availability

of petrol, diesel and LPG. Avoid panic purchases of petrol, diesel and booking of LPG.”

Meanwhile, two more Indian-flagged LPG tankers, carrying roughly a day’s supply of the country’s cooking gas, have safely navigated through the war-hit Strait of Hormuz and are expected to reach Indian shores in the next couple of days.

“Two LPG carriers, BW TYR and BW ELM, carrying a combined LPG cargo of about 94,000 tonnes, have safely transited the region and are moving towards Indian shores,” an official statement said.

While BW TYR is proceeding towards Mumbai with an expected arrival on March 31, BW ELM is en route to New Mangalore with an estimated arrival date of April 1.

Previously, four Indian-flagged LPG tankers had safely sailed through the strait. Pine Gas and Jag Vasant, carrying 92,612 tonnes of LPG, reached Indian ports between March 26 and March 28.

Prior to that, MT Shivalik and MT Nanda Devi, carrying about 92,712 tonnes of LPG, had reached Mundra port in Gujarat on March 16 and Kandla port in the state on March 17, respectively.

# NCLAT rejects BSE plea on Demat account freeze during insolvency

**NEW DELHI:** The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has dismissed the appeals filed by BSE, where the leading bourse challenged the power of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) to defreeze the Demat accounts of businesses undergoing insolvency resolution and liquidation process.

A two-member NCLAT bench said the NCLT has the jurisdiction under section 60 (5) of the Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code (IBC) to entertain applications for defreezing of the Demat accounts during insolvency and pass a direction also. “...the impugned orders have been passed in valid exercise of such jurisdiction,” the NCLAT said while setting aside the two petitions filed by BSE.

BSE had contended that the NCLT does not have any jurisdiction under Section 60 (5) of the IBC Code to adjudicate on the issues, which are within the Securities Law Framework and Sebi Circulars.

The issues pertain to two companies - Future Corporate Resources and Liz Traders and Agents - where their Demat accounts were frozen by BSE due to default committed by them in paying the annual listing fee, among others, as non-compliance with LODR Regulations and unpaid dues from fines levied for such non-compliance.

The Resolution Professionals/liquidators of both the Corporate Debtors (companies facing CIRP) approached the NCLT after BSE refused to



defreeze the Demat accounts of these companies, as they intended to sell the shares held in those accounts and to recover money from the proceeds of such sale.

The Mumbai-bench of the NCLT, passing two separate orders on the two such applications moved by the respective RP, had on October 31, 2025, and July 31, 2024, directed BSE to vacate the freeze.

These orders were subsequently challenged by BSE before the appellate tribunal NCLAT by filing two appeals, which were also dismissed.

Passing a common order over the two petitions, the NCLAT said these applications to defreeze these Demat accounts were moved by the RP and Liquidator for the benefit of the debt-ridden companies, which action is not barred under Section 14 of the IBC.

“The fate of these appeals was dependent on the issue as to whether NCLT was having jurisdiction under Section 60 of the IBC to pass impugned orders, we do not find it relevant to discuss this aspect of the matter at length, as we have already held that NCLT was having jurisdiction under section 60 (5) of the Code to enter-

tain such applications and the impugned orders have been passed in valid exercise of such jurisdiction,” the NCLAT said.

The appellate tribunal further said the ownership of the companies regarding the shares held in those Demat accounts has not been disputed.

“... the defreezing of these Demat accounts of the CD was a question arising out of and in relation to the Insolvency Resolution of the aforesaid CD’s and thus NCLT/Adjudicating Authority was having jurisdiction to pass impugned orders by assuming jurisdiction as provided under Section 60 (5) of the Code and we do not find any illegality in exercise of such jurisdiction by the NCLT,” said a bench, comprising members - Justice Mohd Faiz Alam Khan and Naresh Salecha.

The NCLAT said accounts were frozen on account of dues from those companies, which have become debt due to their finality under the insolvency process.

In that case, the NCLT would have jurisdiction to deal with those dues (debt) under the IBC framework, as they are connected to the insolvency of those companies, said the appellate tribunal.

Rejecting BSE’s jurisdiction plea, NCLAT held the IBC overrides laws like SCRA, SEBI Act and LODR norms during insolvency.

Citing Section 238, it said NCLT can adjudicate all legal or factual issues linked to resolution or liquidation proceedings. AGENCIES

## Gold, silver to remain range-bound next week, say analysts

**NEW DELHI:** Precious metal prices are expected to remain in a corrective phase next week as investors track geopolitical developments in West Asia and key macroeconomic data from major economies for fresh direction, analysts said.

Speeches from Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell on Monday and other Fed officials later in the week will also be closely watched for signals on monetary policy, which is likely to influence bullion demand, they added.

In the domestic market, gold futures ended marginally lower at Rs 1.44 lakh per 10 grams over the past week, while silver settled in the green, rising by Rs 1,182, or 0.52 per cent, to Rs 2.27 lakh per kilogram on the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX).

In the international markets, gold settled nearly 2 per cent lower at \$4,492.5 per ounce, while silver ended the week marginally higher at \$69.79 per ounce.

According to analysts, geopolitical tensions remained a key driver, with escalating conflict in West Asia intensifying volatility in the bullion prices.

Despite temporary relief after US President Donald Trump signalled a 10-day pause on Iran’s energy infrastructure attacks, the dollar index remained near 100, capping gains in bullion, they added. PTI

# Bitcoin declines below key averages, falls to \$66K on bearish sentiment

**NEW DELHI:** Bitcoin slipped to around \$66,000 after sustained bearish sentiment, breaching its 200-day and year-to-date averages—key technical levels that traders track for trend signals.

The breakdown points to near-term downside pressure, driven by global risk-off sentiment and tighter liquidity.

However, the decline has remained orderly, with prices stabilising in the mid-\$60,000 range rather than triggering panic selling.

Analysts say the market is at a crucial juncture. While the breach of key supports warrants caution, expectations of a rebound towards \$68,000 suggest underlying demand



remains intact. Bitcoin continues to closely track broader financial conditions and investor risk appetite.

Recent sessions saw volatility after a period of steady gains, with prices briefly dipping amid weakness in global equities and tightening financial conditions, particularly in Asia, according to WazirX.

Easing geopolitical ten-

sions, including possible talks between the US and Iran, led to a 5–6% fall in oil prices, helping stabilise risk assets, including cryptocurrencies.

Institutional interest remains strong. BlackRock has reiterated its focus on Bitcoin and Ethereum, while MicroStrategy continues to expand its Bitcoin holdings, underscoring long-term conviction.

Bitcoin has traded within a \$50,000–\$70,000 range for nearly two months, indicating an accumulation phase. While macro pressures are easing, sentiment remains fragile, with analysts warning of potential volatility and advising caution, especially on leveraged positions. AGENCIES

# Vedanta chief claims Jaypee bid reversal after written confirmation, analysts question rationale

*Analysts said insolvency outcomes under the IBC depend on creditor consensus and value maximisation rather than headline numbers*

**NEW DELHI:** Mining baron Anil Agarwal on Sunday claimed Vedanta Ltd had received written confirmation of winning the bid for Jaiprakash Associates Ltd, but the decision was later reversed without explanation.

In a social media post, Agarwal said Vedanta was “declared the highest bidder publicly” in the insolvency process. “It was a transparent process. We were informed in writing that we had won. But life is never so simple... the decision was changed,” he said, adding the matter would be addressed at the appropriate forum.

Lenders, however, rejected the claim, saying Vedanta “was

While Vedanta’s Rs 16,726 crore offer had a slightly higher value, Adani’s bid included over Rs 6,000 crore upfront, offering faster recovery and greater certainty

never declared the winning bidder” and that the outcome followed a structured evaluation. Billionaire Gautam Adani’s group was the only rival bidder.

The Committee of Creditors

(CoC) approved a Rs 14,535 crore bid by Adani Enterprises, which was cleared by the National Company Law Tribunal on March 17. The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal has since refused to stay the order and sought responses from lenders, with the next hearing scheduled for April 10.

While Vedanta’s Rs 16,726 crore offer had a slightly higher value, creditors cited concerns over its staggered payments, lower upfront cash and execution risks. Adani’s bid included over Rs 6,000 crore upfront, offering faster recovery and greater certainty.

Analysts said insolvency outcomes under the IBC

depend on creditor consensus and value maximisation rather than headline numbers. The Adani plan secured 93.8 per cent of CoC votes, reflecting lender preference for quicker resolution. Experts also pointed to Vedanta’s past exits and delays in insolvency deals as weighing on confidence, while creditors viewed Adani’s proposal as providing a more reliable and time-bound exit.

JAL, admitted to insolvency in June 2024 with dues exceeding Rs 57,000 crore, has diversified assets across real estate, cement, power and infrastructure, making it one of India’s most closely watched resolution cases. AGENCIES

**NEW DELHI:** Vedanta Ltd will be split into five listed entities early next month, chairman Anil Agarwal said, adding the move would give each business a “free hand to grow”.

The restructuring will create standalone companies for aluminium, zinc, oil and gas, steel, and power. Agarwal said the demerger would unlock significant shareholder value, with market estimates suggesting the combined valuation could exceed the group’s current \$27 billion.

The Mumbai-listed conglomerate, with an enterprise value of about \$37 billion, has been working on the split for years to streamline operations and address its debt burden, which stands at around \$11 billion.

The new entities will together carry about \$7 bil-



Vedanta chairman Anil Agarwal

lion in debt, while a promoter-controlled parent will retain roughly half the shareholding in each.

The plan, which earlier faced resistance from the government, moved ahead after Vedanta successfully overturned a legal challenge last year.

Amid global energy volatility linked to tensions in Iran, Agarwal also called for boosting domestic oil and gas production. He said India’s dependence on imports

The restructuring will create standalone firms for aluminium, zinc, oil and gas, steel, and power

remains a key vulnerability. Vedanta’s oil arm, Cairn Oil and Gas, aims to double output to 1 million barrels of oil equivalent per day over the next six years.

India currently imports over 80 per cent of its crude needs, largely from the Middle East.

Vedanta’s shares remain near record highs, supported by firm commodity prices, despite the group recently losing out to Adani Enterprises in the race to acquire Jaiprakash Associates. AGENCIES

# Housing sales in Delhi-NCR dip 17% q-o-q in Jan-March amid West Asia conflict: Anarock

*Housing sales in Delhi-NCR stood at 15,985 units during the current January-March period, down from 19,250 units in the previous quarter*

**NEW DELHI:** Housing sales in Delhi-NCR declined 17 per cent quarter-on-quarter to nearly 16,000 units in the January-March period amid negative sentiments due to the West Asia conflict, according to Anarock.

However, the demand rose 44 per cent on an annual basis following the low base effect.

Real estate consultant Anarock data showed that housing sales in Delhi-NCR stood at 15,985 units during the current January-March period, down 17 per cent from 19,250 units in the previous quarter.

Sales in Delhi-NCR increased 44 per cent from

11,120 units in the January-March period of the last year.

Anarock Chairman Anuj Puri noted that the long-term fundamentals of India’s residential segment remain strong, but the “short-term tremors of the Iran War were clearly visible in the first quarter”.

He pointed out that the war-induced uncertainty has affected buying sentiments, particularly in March, resulting in a 7 per cent decline in sales across seven major cities during the January-March period of this year against the previous quarter.

“The decline also aligns with



large numbers of prospective Middle East homebuyers, who invest significantly in Indian real estate, hitting the pause button under the war cloud,” Puri said.

Commenting on the demand scenario in the Delhi-

## CLOSER LOOK

- » However, sales in Delhi-NCR increased 44 per cent from 11,120 units in January-March period of the last year
- » As per the Anarock data, housing sales rose 9 per cent annually in January-March across the top seven cities
- » But declined 7 per cent from the previous quarter amid global economic uncertainties amid the West Asia conflict

NCR market, Rishi Raj, CEO of Consient Infrastructure, said, “The NCR market continues to demonstrate resilient demand, though growth is clearly becoming more K-shaped, with momentum increasingly concentrated in select micro-mar-

kets and product categories”.

Homebuyers are becoming increasingly discerning and are gravitating towards developments that seamlessly bring together location, quality, and experience, backed by credible institutions with strong balance

sheets, he added.

Ashish Jerath, President - Sales & Marketing at Smartworld Developers, said Noida and Greater Noida housing markets have great potential for growth, with the international airport becoming operational. He noted that the NCR property market is likely to gradually move away from speculative activities.

As per the Anarock data, housing sales rose 9 per cent annually in January-March across the top seven cities, but declined 7 per cent from the previous quarter amid global economic uncertainties amid

the West Asia conflict.

Sales increased to 1,01,675 units during the current quarter from 93,280 units in the year-ago period.

Sales in value terms grew 6 per cent to Rs 1.51 lakh crore during the January-March period from Rs 1.42 lakh crore in the corresponding period of the preceding year.

Anarock, however, pointed out that housing sales fell 7 per cent in volume terms and 6 per cent value-wise from the previous quarter.

In the fourth quarter of the 2025 calendar year, as many as 1,08,970 units were sold for Rs

1.60 lakh crore.

The seven major cities are Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune, Chennai and Kolkata.

On a quarterly basis, all seven cities have witnessed a decline in sales. However, on an annual basis, only Pune has seen a demand slowdown.

Mumbai-based Anarock is one of the leading housing brokerage firms in the country. It also provides consultancy services for leasing of commercial (office, retail and warehousing) real estate spaces, land acquisition and fundraising. PTI



INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE

Rohit, Rickelton’s blistering fifties power MI to 6-wicket win over KKR

MUMBAI: Mumbai Indians rode on blistering half-centuries from former skipper Rohit Sharma (78) and Ryan Rickelton (81) to comfortably beat Kolkata Knight Riders by six wickets thus breaking the hoodoo of not winning any of their opening games in last 13 editions of the IPL, here on Sunday. While they had lost each of their first matches of an IPL edition since beating Chennai Super Kings by eight wickets in 2012, five-time winners Mumbai Indians hit full throttle in their chase of 221, replying with 224/4 in 19.1 overs.

Playing his first T20 game since last IPL, former India and Mumbai Indians captain Rohit appeared to have sharpened his game a few notches as he smacked a 38-ball 78 with six sixes and as many fours.

At the other end, Ryan Rickelton made a belligerent 81 off 43 balls with eight sixes and four fours while making the most of two lifelines, helping Mumbai Indians finally collect those elusive two points from the first game.

Rohit was adroit in not just picking the lengths of the ball early or with his movement at the crease, but with some of the shots that he executed to perfection. Like against the lanky Blessing Muzarabani,



Mumbai Indians' Rohit Sharma (right), and Ryan Rickelton run between the wickets during an IPL match b, at the Wankhede Stadium, in Mumbai on Sunday

the 38-year-old danced down the track to spank a short ball over extra cover for a six in the fourth over, or when he timed the ball as sweetly as it could be against Varun Chakravarthy to send it sailing over the cover for

another six in the next. And those quintessential Rohit's hits over cover were on display too, one of which was unleashed effortlessly against Kartik Tyagi in the sixth as Rohit completed his half-cen-

tury off a mere 23 balls.

At the other end, Rickelton blissfully took down KKR's mystery spin duo of Sunil Narine and Chakravarthy, tar-

Rahane began with a wristy flick over wide long-on with exquisite timing for a six off Boult in the first over

Rohit and Rickelton put on 148 off 72 balls to put MI in the driver's seat before falling to Anukul Roy's brilliance in the outfield. It was the fifth-wicket pair of Hardik Pandya (18 not out) and Naman Dhir (5 not out) that took MI over the line.

Earlier, skipper Ajinkya Rahane (67) and Angkrish Raghuvanshi (51) struck vital half-centuries but Kolkata Knight Riders posted a par score of 220 for 4. On a placid wicket, Shardul Thakur (3/39) provided Mumbai crucial breakthroughs as their bowlers could not really impose themselves in their maiden out-

ing. Both senior pacers Trent Boult (0/38) and Jasprit Bumrah (0/35) went wicketless but India pace spearhead's 18th and 20th over stopped KKR from getting closer to 250.

Rahane began with a wristy flick over wide long-on with exquisite timing for a six off Boult in the first over. AGENCIES

Samson, Jadeja face former teams as new-look CSK meet Parag’s RR

GUWAHATI: Sanju Samson is set for an emotional clash against Rajasthan Royals, the side he led and shaped for over a decade, as he turns out for Chennai Super Kings, while Ravindra Jadeja will also face his former franchise, adding a poignant sub-plot to the IPL match between the two teams here on Monday.

For more than a decade, Samson was synonymous with RR, their batting mainstay, leader and all-time leading run-scorer who guided them to the 2022 final.

Much like MS Dhoni at CSK, Samson was the Royals' identity, but in a blockbuster swap that sent Jadeja back to RR, the Kerala batter now finds himself in yellow, adding a new dimension to CSK's evolving core.

Samson also arrives in prime form, having played a decisive role in India's triumphant T20 World Cup campaign.

His hat-trick of 50-plus scores in must-win games against West Indies, England and New Zealand has made him the star of the nation as the unassuming keeper-batter will come with a renewed self-belief.

He along with skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad, who are set to open also, will also form the core leadership of the team who will miss Dhoni for at least two weeks due to a calf strain.

Dhoni has not travelled with the side to Guwahati as



Rajasthan Royals' Vaibhav Sooryavanshi plays a shot during a practice session ahead of match between Rajasthan Royals and Chennai Super Kings, in Guwahati on Sunday

**TEAMS:**  
**Rajasthan Royals:** Riyan Parag (c), Dhruv Jurel, Donovan Ferreira, Lhuan-Dre Pretorius, Ravi Singh, Aman Perala, Shimron Hetmyer, Shubham Dubey, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Ravindra Jadeja, Sam Curran, Adam Milne, Brijesh Sharma, Jofra Archer, Kuldeep Sen, Kwena Maphaka, Nandre Burger, Ravi Bishnoi and Sandeep Sharma.  
**Chennai Super Kings:** Sanju Samson, Dewald Brevis, Shivam Dube, Ruturaj Gaikwad (c), Ayush Mhatre, Matt Henry, Akeal Hosein, Noor Ahmad, Jamie Overton, Matthew Short, Khaleel Ahmed, Zak Foulkes, Anshul Khamboj, Nathan Ellis, Sarfaraz Khan, Rahul Chahar, Kartik Sharma, Urvil Patel, Aman Khan, Ramakrishna Ghosh, Prashant Veer, Shreyas Gopal, Gurjapneet Singh and Mukesh Choudhary.

his absence will put Samson and Gaikwad in the spotlight.

Dhoni's absence will also open the door for emerging names like 20-year-old left-arm spin all-rounder Prashant Veer who impressed in domestic T20s and the franchise's big-money (Rs 14.2-core) uncapped recruit

Kartik Sharma, known for his six-hitting exploits in the domestic circuit. With Dewald Brevis showing signs of maturity, Shivam Dube growing into a dependable middle-order force, and youngster Ayush Mhatre developing rapidly, CSK appear better equipped for a rebuild. AGENCIES

‘Gypsy King’ Hari Singh leaves motorsports fraternity in tears

S.KANNAN

NEW DELHI: This has to be one of the saddest stories of a legend in Indian sports passing away, yet the news of death not being confirmed, officially. Hari Singh, referred to as ‘Gypsy King’ for his exploits at the wheels of cars from Fiat to Ambassador and Maruti to Volkswagen Polo and Mercedes, went ‘missing’ in the Maldives Waters on March 20, when the speedboat of industrialist Gautam Singhania met with an accident.

Since that fateful day, no news has been heard of Hari Singh, the six feet and three inches tall legend from Chandigarh.

On Monday, in Chandigarh, wife Simran Kaur, daughter Azmat, a pilot with Air India and son Mivaan will be part of a prayer meeting at a Gurdwara for Hari Singh.

“This is indeed sad, we have no update as such after the search was called off officially on Friday,” said Sunny, a close friend of Hari Singh, who is in a state of shock.

In fact, the entire motorsports community in India is in tears since news broke out of Hari Singh going missing.

Officially, as per law, Hari Singh's family does not even have a death certificate. However, they will be going ahead with the prayer meeting at the Sector 8 Gurdwara in Chandigarh from 12 noon to 1pm.

For more than 36 years, Hari Singh has been part of



Hari Singh

Where Hari Singh's real talent lay was in advising kids. He shared his rich experience with younger drivers, notably, Gaurav Gill, Sanam Sekhon and many more

Indian motorsports, having begun at the Himalayan Rally in 1990. Close friends of the 59-year-old recall the Sardar as brilliant behind the wheels. His daring and stunts left people in awe.

In many conversations with this writer, the last being in November 2025 at the Kari Motor Speedway in Coimbatore, Hari Singh, who was the face of JK Tyre Motorsport programme, spoke of how there has been progression.

“The new generation has access to better vehicles, safety, be it in rallying or racing,” said Hari, who has mentored several generations.

Tributes to him have been

paid by the father and son duo of Vicky and Karun Chandhok, themselves well-known in the field of motorsports.

Where Hari Singh's real talent lay was in advising kids. He shared his rich experience with younger drivers, notably, Gaurav Gill, Sanam Sekhon and many more.

Even at 59, Hari never feared when he was at the wheels performing stunts on the race track. His mastery at the wheels, while ‘burning tyre’ left all in awe.

Sadly, when he left Chandigarh, the family never knew they would never see him again.

The search for Hari Singh and Mahesh Ramachandran, an ex-Indian Navy officer, who was also on the speedboat, continued till Friday night. Drones, divers, all was pressed into action, but the bodies have not been traced.

To call of the search means intense pain.

During the old days of fierce rallying, Hari Singh was the master at the wheels.

His daring, speed and ability to tame ‘rally stages’ was breathtaking.

As someone who was involved with the safety angle of racing at the FMSCI and on the race tracks, Hari would never have dreamt his exit would be in waters.

The multiple national champion leave behind a treasure trove of memories, of a man always smiling and willing to help.

Sadly, Indian motorsports stands orphaned in the passing of Hari Singh.

BENGALURU: All praise for Virat Kohli, former off-spinner Ravichandran Ashwin says the Indian stalwart continues to “walk the talk” with his unmatched energy and intensity despite having retired from Test and T20I formats.

Returning to T20 cricket for the first time since last year's IPL final on June 3, Kohli showed no signs of rust, smashing his 28th IPL half-century (69 not out off 38 balls) to power defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru to a commanding six-wicket win over Sunrisers Hyderabad in the 2026 season-opener.

“He walks the talk,” Ashwin said on a JioHotstar show. “It's almost like he's putting on a show for people to see how the game should be played, play it hard and play it the way it's meant to be played. That stood out for me with respect to what Virat did.”

Kohli was already in sublime touch coming into the IPL, having scored 93, 23 and 124 in the ODI series against New Zealand in January, where he finished as India's leading run-getter.

The 37-year-old had also topped the charts in the preceding series against South Africa in December, amassing 302 runs, including two centuries.

Ashwin further cited example of his running between the wickets to show how his energy remains extraordinary despite his age and experience.

“I find him quite bizarre at this age. I tell him this during our chats now and then. He was batting on 40-odd, there



Virat Kohli

was a partnership going on, and RCB were coasting.

“He ran through for the first single, stopped there, and the other batter hadn't even reached halfway, but he was already looking for a second. That was a 57-metre boundary on the leg side, and it shows the enthusiasm he still brings to the game,” added Ashwin.

The premier Indian off-spinner turned commentator also highlighted the performance of Jacob Duffy, who turned it around after a woe-

Having endured a tough outing in the T20 World Cup conceding over 10 runs per over and managing just three wickets, Duffy bounced back in style with a dream IPL debut for RCB as he ripped through the Sunrisers Hyderabad top order with figures of 3/22.

He removed the dangerous opening duo of Abhishek Sharma and Travis Head, along with Nitish Kumar Reddy, triggering an early collapse as SRH stumbled at the start before recovering to 201/9, a total that proved below par at the Chinnaswamy. AGENCIES

Indian boxers seek strong start in Asian meet

The tournament will feature several Olympic medallists, and rising stars

ULAANBAATAR: Indian boxers will aim for a good show at the Asian Championships, beginning here on Monday, as they look to make the most of their opportunities in a packed season and secure direct berths for the multi-sport events later this year.

The tournament marks the first major outing in a loaded season that includes the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow (July-August), the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan (September-October) and the World Boxing Cup Finals in Uzbekistan.

Apart from the medal rush, the championships assume added significance as finalists will earn direct qualification for the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games, in line with the Boxing Federation of India's selection policy.



Indian team has been acclimatising in Mongolia for the past 15 days

The Indian team has been acclimatising in Mongolia for the past 15 days, training in multinational camps and sparring with boxers from Mongolia, China, Jordan and Thailand.

The women's challenge will be led by Olympic medalist Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), two-time world champion Nikhat Zareen (51kg), reigning world champions Minakshi

Hooda (48kg) and Jaismine Lamboria (57kg).

While Lovlina comes in after a gold-winning effort at the Boxam International in Spain in February, it will be the first international outing since November for Zareen, Hooda and Jaismine.

“These Asian Championships will be a strong test. We know that Asian boxing has improved the level over the last

Sachin will take on local favourite Buyandalai Bayarkhuu, Aditya faces Saudi Arabia's Mouda Alhawsaw

decade, many of the world's strongest teams are in Asia,” women's head coach Santiago Nieva told PTL.

“Our history tells us that we can win medals. So, we are targeting several medals, but for us it is important to have people in the final, and there's not many times we've had more than one gold, and obviously a gold medal makes a difference.

In the women's draw, Preeti Pawar will face Elina Bazarova

of Kazakhstan in the 54kg category, while Priya takes on Kazakh boxer Rimma Volos-senko in 60 kg.

Minakshi will face Japan's Yuka Sadamatusu, while Pooja Rani be up against Kazakhstan's Nadezhda Ryabets.

Zareen, Jaismine, Ankushita Boro, Arundhati Choudhary, Borgohain, and Alfiya Patahan have received first-round byes.

While the women are expected to deliver, the men's team has ground to make up after a disappointing World Championships campaign last year, where the male boxers failed to win a medal for the first time in 12 years. There has also been a change in the coaching setup, with army-man C.A. Kuttappa returning for a third stint as head coach. AGENCIES

Pramod Bhagat leads India's charge in Para Badminton International

TOLEDO: Paralympic champion Pramod Bhagat bagged one gold and two silver medals, leading India's impressive performance at the Spanish Para Badminton International 2026 – Level 1 here.

Bhagat's campaign was highlighted by a gold medal finish in the mixed doubles

SL3-SU5 category, where he partnered Manisha Ramdass.

The Indian duo displayed excellent chemistry and resilience as it defeated compatriots Nitesh Kumar and Thulasimathi Murugesan 21-15 24-22 in 30 minutes. AGENCIES

Bharat Coking Coal Limited (A Mini Ratna Company) (A Subsidiary of Coal India Limited)

NOTICE

All the tenders issued by Bharat Coking Coal Limited (B.C.C.L.) for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of B.C.C.L. “www.bccweb.in” Coal India Limited (CIL) e-procurement portal “https://coalindiatenders.nic.in” and Central Public Procurement Portal “https://eprocure.gov.in” In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal “https://gem.gov.in”. This is applicable to all Open (Domestic / Global) Tenders issued through e-procurement portal of CIL. This information is also available on BCCCL website www.bccweb.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Deepak @ Batta S/o Raj Pal R/o Jhuggi No. 100, Sanjay Camp, Haiderpur, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide E Fir No. 4751/2016, U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS Mangolpuri, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused Deepak @ Batta can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Deepak @ Batta has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Deepak @ Batta of E Fir No. 4751/2016, U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS Mangolpuri, Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 30.04.2026

By Order, Ms. Reetika Jain Judicial Magistrate First Class-05 North-West. Court No. 105 Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/4039/OD/2026(Court Matter)

National Highways Authority of India (Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Govt. of India) PIU- Rewari, Plot No.-20, Sector-32, Institutional Area, Gurgaon-122003 E-mail: piurewari@nhai.org

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public is hereby informed that the revised user fee rates approved by the Competent Authority that are to be charged for the use of section for Section from Km 0.000 (Design Ch.) to Km 31.240 (Design Ch.) (Length 31.240 Km) of NH-148B and Narnaul to Pachri Kalan from Km 0.000 (Design Ch.) to Km 11.300 (Design Ch.) (Length 11.300 Km) of NH-11 w.e.f. 01.04.2026 (00:00 hrs) at Sirohi Bahali Fee Plaza (Km 23.000), Village Sirohi Bahali, District Mahendergarh, Haryana in the State of Haryana are as following:-

| Schedule of Fee (In Rupees)                                                                                |                              |                                                                      |                                                 |                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Category of Vehicles                                                                                       | Fee for Single Journey (Rs.) | Fee for multiple (max. no of two one way) Journey within a day (Rs.) | Fee for Monthly Pass valid for 50 Journey (Rs.) | Commercial Vehicles registered within the district (excluding vehicles plying under National Permit) (Rs.) |
| Car/ Jeep/Van or Light Motor Vehicle                                                                       | 140                          | 205                                                                  | 4585                                            | 70                                                                                                         |
| Light Commercial vehicle, Light Goods Vehicle or Mini Bus                                                  | 220                          | 335                                                                  | 7405                                            | 110                                                                                                        |
| Bus or Truck (Two Axle)                                                                                    | 465                          | 700                                                                  | 15520                                           | 235                                                                                                        |
| Three-Axle Commercial Vehicle                                                                              | 510                          | 760                                                                  | 16930                                           | 255                                                                                                        |
| Heavy Construction Machinery (HCM) or Earth Moving Equipment (ME) or Multi Axle Vehicle (MAV to Six Axles) | 730                          | 1095                                                                 | 24340                                           | 365                                                                                                        |
| Oversized Vehicle (Seven or more Axles)                                                                    | 890                          | 1335                                                                 | 29630                                           | 445                                                                                                        |

The rates of monthly pass applicable for local non-commercial vehicle and residents within a distance of 20 Km. from the user fee plaza for the FY 2026-27 shall be Rs. 350/- & Annual pass for non-commercial vehicle for FY 2026-27 shall be Rs. 3075/- subject to revision every year as per provisions of The National Highways Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Rules, 2008 and its amendments, if any.

Project Director, PIU- Rewari

Building a Nation, Not Just Roads



# Dia recalls being tagged ‘bad luck’

Mirza made her Bollywood debut 25 years ago with ‘Rehnaa Hai Terre Dil Mein’



Dia Mirza made her Bollywood debut 25 years ago with ‘Rehnaa Hai Terre Dil Mein’, a film that has since achieved cult status among audiences. But when it was first released, it failed at the box office, followed by her many projects failing despite her performances receiving praise.

In a recent conversation, Dia opened up about being labelled ‘unlucky’ in the industry and how she eventually found a turning point with Rajkumar Hirani’s ‘Sanju’. Looking back at her initial years in Bollywood, Dia said she had to fight preconceived notions about her constantly.

“I feel I managed to defy everybody’s idea of me and create my own. When I started, there were numerous comparisons with Aishwarya Rai. I remember impending access to an opportunity. Then box office failures of my so-called big films - and how it in turn renders you jobless, because people who were otherwise queuing up to sign you suddenly perceive you as a ‘panauti’, bad luck. I have been through all of that.” Despite the setbacks, she

said critics often acknowledged her potential, even when opportunities didn’t follow. “If you go back and read some of the reviews from my first five years in films, you see critics saying ‘deserves more’, ‘underutilised’ and ‘not getting her due’.”

Dia also spoke about stepping away from work at a young age following a personal loss. “I took a sabbatical at the age of 24 when I lost my adoptive father. I was like, ‘Something is wrong here. I am working hard. I am doing my best, but people’s expectations of me aren’t matching what is happening to me.’”

The actress revealed that things began to change after she actively reached out to filmmaker Rajkumar Hirani during the casting of ‘Sanju’. “There has always been this desire to do more, and I think it’s only in the last decade, post ‘Sanju’. I remember the phone call I made to Rajkumar Hirani when he was casting the film. I had already done ‘Lage Raho Munna Bhai’ with him and I said, ‘Please give me work, please. I have no work and I am struggling to find an opportunity to get a foothold. Nobody is giving me jobs. You are doing this film and I promise I will do a screen test.’”

AGENCIES

She opened up about being labelled ‘unlucky’ in the industry and how she eventually found a turning point with Rajkumar Hirani’s ‘Sanju’



## ‘Have become more of a tigress since embracing motherhood’

In 2025, Bollywood Kiara Advani welcomed her first child, daughter Saraayah Malhotra, with husband Sidharth Malhotra. Since then, she has been focusing on her family and her newborn. However, the actress is now set to make her return to the big screen with Yash-starrer ‘Toxic’, which will also mark her Telugu debut. Recently, she opened up about being a new mom and how her life has changed after embracing motherhood.

Speaking to ‘Grazia’, Kiara shared that after welcoming her daughter, she feels more independent as she is ‘running our own home or creating our little universe together’, yet she feels ‘everything else is the same’. She said, “Before marriage, Sidharth (Malhotra) and I had the same banter and had fun travelling so those things still remain. We also watch movies together and since we look at it as cinema lovers or as the audience, as well as actors, we get

Advani is now set to make her return to the big screen with Yash-starrer ‘Toxic’

excited to discuss it.”

Talking about how she has become more protective after becoming a mother, she said, “I’ve become more of a tigress. The way I see life now is through a completely different lens. It’s like nothing else matters and at the same time, everything matters.”

Director Geetu Mohandas, who cast her in ‘Toxic’ (2026), lauded Kiara and revealed that she was her first choice for the role of Nadia in the film. Geetu said, “Nadia (portrayed by Advani) embodies fragility and ferocity at once, so from the very beginning, she was my first and only choice. There is something about her screen presence that feels deeply human.”

AGENCIES

## You must always have a plan: Boman Irani

NEW DELHI: Actor Boman Irani believes one must always have a plan and keep working, creating and reinventing oneself.

Irani attended the International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) on Friday.

“You are never too old to do anything, ese kabhi mt sochna ki mera time nikal gaya hai. There is nothing like that,” the actor told reporters during an interaction.

He added, “Till the very end, you can keep on working, creating, reinventing yourself. You must always have a plan. Everybody is young as long as you have the heart to do it.”

The International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) 2026 will screen 140 films from 47 countries across multiple venues in the national capital during its run.

The festival opened at Bharat Mandapam on March 25 and will conclude on March 31. The film gala is organised by the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) in association with the Delhi government.

PTI



# ‘NO FUN IN HOW action films are made today’

Akshay Kumar is all for action films that are raw and real, unlike the prevalent picture-perfect versions that are being done with the help of VFX and AI in the film industry.

One of the original action stars in Hindi cinema and skilled in martial art forms such as Karate, Muay Thai, Taekwondo and Kudo, Kumar isn’t happy with the shift towards technology when it comes to shooting action sequences.

“There is a huge difference in the way action films are being made today. Earlier, the action would be real. Now, everything is done in VFX. It’s not fun as it feels fake. I want to make a film that is real. For instance, if I’m jumping, then I’m jumping for real and not using VFX for it or if I’m kicking, then I’m kicking for real, not like 15 people are helping me kick people. I want to make an action film without the use of VFX,” Kumar told PTI.

The actor started his journey

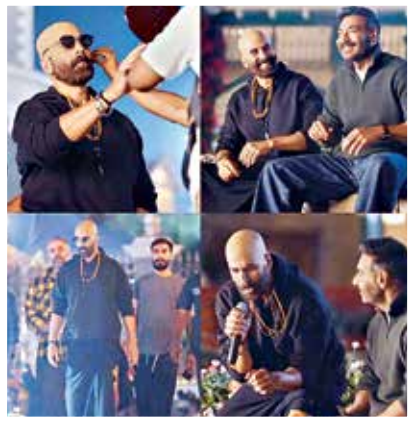
‘Earlier, the action would be real. Now, everything is done in VFX. It’s not fun as it feels fake,’ he says

in Hindi cinema as an action star delivering hits through the ‘Khiladi’ franchise, ‘Mohra’, ‘Suhaag’, ‘Elaan’ and ‘Jaanwar’ before making a shift towards drama, comedy and movies with socially relevant themes.

In recent years, Kumar has featured in action entertainers like ‘Holiday’, ‘Gabbar is Back’, and ‘Sooryavanshi’.

Kumar, 58, isn’t a fan of the film industry’s growing reliance on Artificial Intelligence (AI) as he believes it’s easy to spot a difference between the actual action sequences versus those generated with the help of a computer.

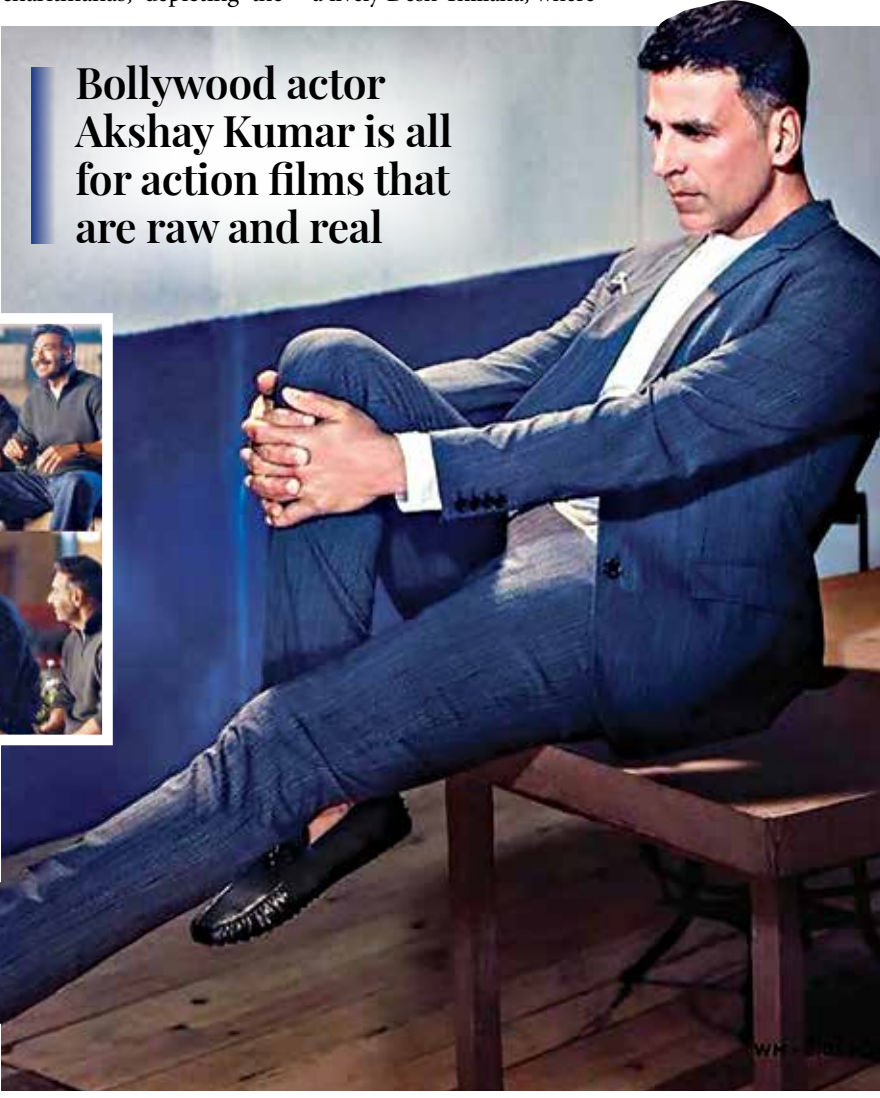
“I’m saying this in the era of AI and people may think what they wish to, but I want



to do an action film that is a real action film. The audience can feel how much effort is being put in.”

AGENCIES

Bollywood actor Akshay Kumar is all for action films that are raw and real



## MATKA KING

# A tale of ambition & power

To release on April 17, it is an intense drama set in the fast-changing Bombay of the 1960s

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video’ celebrated Vijay Varma’s birthday by announcing April 17 as the worldwide premiere date of his upcoming ‘Prime Original’ drama ‘Matka King’. Created and written by Abhay Koranne and created and directed by Nagraj Popatrao Manjule, the series is produced by Siddharth Roy Kapur, Nagraj Popatrao Manjule, Gargi Kulkarni, Ashwini Sidwani, and Ashish Aryan, under the banners of ‘Roy Kapur Films’, ‘Aatpat’ and ‘SMR Productions’.

Featuring Vijay Varma, Kritika Kamra, Sai Tamhankar, Siddharth Jadhav, Bhupendra Jadawat, and Gulshan Grover in lead roles along with Vineet Kumar Singh, Bharat Jadhav, Girish Kulkarni, Jamie Lever and many others in pivotal roles, ‘Matka King’ follows Brij Bhatti, a sharp-minded and enterprising cotton trader, played by the dynamic Vijay Varma, who navigates the fast-changing landscape of 1960s Bombay in pursuit of legitimacy and respect. Set against a world of bustling markets, crowded chawls and shifting power dynamics, what begins as an ambitious idea soon takes on a life of its own, drawing in people across social strata. As aspirations grow and stakes rise, the series unfolds into



The series features Vijay Varma, Kritika Kamra, Sai Tamhankar, Siddharth Jadhav, Bhupendra Jadawat and Gulshan Grover in lead roles

a gripping narrative shaped by ambition, power and belonging.

“‘Matka King’ is a gripping story of one man’s journey to succeed against all odds in a changing world, told in a way that will surprise audiences. The tale of Brij Bhatti’s rise as the Mata King is equal parts fascinating and cautionary. We are thrilled to have partnered with ‘Roy Kapur Films’, ‘Aatpat’ and ‘SMR Productions’ to bring this bold story to viewers worldwide on April 17,” said Nikhil Madhok, director & head of ‘Originals’, ‘Prime Video’, India.

Co-producer Siddharth Roy Kapur shared, “What drew us to ‘Matka King’ was the scale and uniqueness of the world it is set in and the story of an individual navigating ambition, identity and the pursuit of respect in a rapidly evolving

society. It’s a narrative rooted in a specific time and place, yet universally relatable in its exploration of human aspirations and choices. Combining forces with Nagraj Popatrao Manjule, whose extraordinary work I have always admired, has been extremely rewarding. And the talented Abhay Koranne, whom we have successfully collaborated with before, has brought a distinct creative vision and authenticity to the storytelling.”

“With a stellar ensemble led by Vijay Varma, Kritika Kamra and Gulshan Grover, the series is brought to life with remarkable depth and nuance. We are delighted to deepen our collaboration with ‘Prime Video’ on this ambitious project and look forward to bringing ‘Matka King’ to audiences starting April 17, only on ‘Prime Video’,” he added.

## TANUSHA TYAGI’S ‘ODYSSEY OF LOVE’



### OUR CORRESPONDENT

At the LTG Auditorium, a soulful evening of Bharatanatyam unfolded as ‘Aayam’ presented ‘Odyssey of Love’, a solo recital by Tanusha Tyagi, disciple of Guru Sindhu Mishra. Conceived and choreographed by the Guru, the performance sought to trace love in its many resonances: cosmic, devotional and deeply human, through the cosmic Shiva-Parvati pair.

Structured as a traditional ‘Margam’, the recital opened with an invocation to Ganesha and Shiva. The ‘Ganesh Kriti’, set in raga Nattai, established a tone of auspiciousness, with Tyagi’s vibrant movements carrying both the joy of praying to the Lord and years of tedious

practice. This was followed by ‘Bho Shambho’ in Revathi, where the dancer moved between stillness and fluidity, invoking Shiva not merely as the cosmic dancer but as a compassionate, omnipresent force.

The central ‘Padma Varanam’, drawing from the ‘Ramcharitmanas’, explored Parvati’s steadfast devotion. Here, Tyagi carried the dual demands of ‘nritta’ and ‘abhinaya’ with sincerity and grace. The narrative - Parvati’s penance and her testing by the Saptarishis - was rendered with emotional clarity.

A more unusual presentation came with the ‘Padam’, again sourced from the ‘Ramcharitmanas’, depicting the

At the LTG Auditorium, a soulful evening of Bharatanatyam unfolded as ‘Aayam’ presented ‘Odyssey of Love’, a solo recital by Tanusha Tyagi

rhythmic agility took precedence. Tyagi’s footwork here was energetic, providing a fittingly vibrant close to this deep, contemplative evening.

The live orchestra - featuring G Elangovan (Carnatic vocals and flute), Nitin Sharma (Hindustani vocals), Sachin Sharma (tabla) and Dr Ramamurthy Kesavan (mridangam) - offered a textured musical canvas. Guru Sindhu Mishra’s ‘nattuvangam’ anchored the performance, maintaining cohesion across the repertoire.

‘Odyssey of Love’ remained anchored in its thematic intent - exploring love as surrender, endurance and transcendence.

wedding of Shiva and Parvati through the eyes of a startled and resistant maternal gaze. The tension between fear and faith was delicately suggested, with Tyagi’s abhinaya depicting the nuance in Maena’s disbelief and Parvati’s quiet resolve.

The recital concluded with a lively Desh Thillana, where